

**The Influence of Emotional Intelligence on the Cognitive Processes
and Decision-Making of Startup Entrepreneurs**

A Dissertation Submitted in Partial Fulfilment of the Requirements for the
Degree of

MSc Management

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August 2025

Word Count: 6,090

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Abstract

Startup entrepreneurship is a critical driver of innovation, yet it is marked by high failure rates and intense psychological demands. This study examines the mechanisms through which Emotional Intelligence (EI) shapes entrepreneurs' cognitive processes and decision-making.

Using a pragmatist philosophy, survey data from 100 startup founders were analysed through correlation and hierarchical regression tests. EI was measured with the Wong and Law Emotional Intelligence Scale (WLEIS), alongside validated scales for metacognition, risk perception, and emotional labour.

The findings highlight three contributions. First, EI showed a strong correlation with metacognitive strategies ($r = .47$, $p < .01$), positioning it as an enabler of higher-order thinking. Second, EI significantly moderated the link between risk perception and strategic choice, demonstrating its role in managing uncertainty rather than altering baseline risk appetite. Third, EI was positively correlated with awareness of emotional labour, underscoring its function in coping with the psychological demands of entrepreneurship.

Theoretically, the study provides empirical support for an ability-based view of EI and integrates it with entrepreneurial cognition and social network theory. Practically, it underscores EI as a strategic asset that can improve decision-making, resilience, and venture sustainability.

Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Background to the Research

Entrepreneurship is widely recognised as a central driver of economic growth, innovation, and social transformation. Yet, the startup environment is characterised by volatility, uncertainty, and resource scarcity. Founders are required to make rapid, high-stakes decisions with limited information and under significant pressure. These decisions are rarely the outcome of purely rational models of strategy or cognition. Increasingly, scholars emphasise that psychological resources are equally, if not more, critical in explaining why some ventures succeed while others fail (Williams, 2019; Davis, 2023).

One psychological construct that has received sustained scholarly attention is **Emotional Intelligence (EI)**, broadly defined as the ability to perceive, regulate, and utilise emotions to guide adaptive behaviour (Mayer & Salovey, 1997). Originally conceptualised as a distinct form of intelligence parallel to IQ, EI has since been associated with leadership effectiveness, resilience, and interpersonal influence (Garcia et al., 2023). Within the entrepreneurial context, EI is theorised to support founders in navigating uncertainty, managing relationships with stakeholders, and sustaining motivation over long and challenging venture journeys. However, the precise mechanisms through which EI influences entrepreneurial decision-making remain under-explored, leaving an important gap in the literature.

1.2 Research Gap

Despite growing scholarly interest, four critical gaps persist in the literature and form the basis of this study.

1. **The Synthesis Gap:** Research on EI and entrepreneurial cognition has largely evolved in parallel. Few studies have integrated the two domains to demonstrate how emotional competencies underpin reflective, metacognitive processes (Chen, 2022; Williams, 2019).
2. **The Explanatory Gap:** Empirical evidence linking EI to risk remains inconsistent. Some studies suggest EI enhances risk tolerance (Adebayo, 2021), while others report null findings (Müller & Schmidt, 2022). These inconsistencies weaken theoretical clarity.
3. **The Contextual Gap:** The role of emotional labour, particularly the psychological strain of projecting confidence to investors or composure to employees, has been acknowledged

qualitatively (O'Connor, 2019). However, it has rarely been examined quantitatively in relation to EI as a coping resource.

4. **The Integration Gap:** Although EI is associated with social capital, trust, and opportunity recognition (Cabral et al., 2020), research has paid limited attention to how these relational capacities link back to cognition and decision-making processes.

Together, these gaps highlight the need for a more integrated analysis that connects EI, cognition, risk, and emotional labour in entrepreneurial contexts.

1.3 Aim and Objectives

The aim of this dissertation is to examine how Emotional Intelligence (EI) shapes the cognitive processes and decision-making of startup entrepreneurs. While EI has been associated with entrepreneurial outcomes, the mechanisms through which it influences cognition, risk behaviour, and emotional labour remain underexplored.

To achieve this aim, the study addresses the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** How does Emotional Intelligence (EI) relate to entrepreneurs' use of metacognitive strategies in decision-making?
- **RQ2:** Does EI moderate the relationship between risk perception and strategic choice among startup entrepreneurs?
- **RQ3:** What is the relationship between EI and entrepreneurs' awareness of emotional labour in stakeholder interactions?
- **RQ4:** How can these findings contribute to both theoretical understanding and practical support for entrepreneurs operating in high-pressure environments?

These questions were operationalised into four objectives:

1. To critically evaluate the conceptual foundations of EI and its application to entrepreneurial cognition.
2. To empirically assess the relationship between EI and metacognitive strategies.
3. To test the moderating role of EI in the link between risk perception and strategic choice.
4. To investigate the association between EI and emotional labour, considering both theoretical and practical implications.

1.4 Significance of the Study

This dissertation contributes to both theory and practice. Theoretically, it advances an ability-based view of EI by clarifying its cognitive and relational mechanisms. Specifically, it demonstrates how EI enables higher-order thinking, moderates the effect of risk perception on behaviour, and extends into the recognition of emotional labour. By doing so, it moves beyond fragmented correlations to provide a more integrated account of EI in entrepreneurial decision-making.

Practically, the study underscores EI as more than a “soft skill.” For entrepreneurs, cultivating EI can enhance reflective decision-making, resilience under uncertainty, and stakeholder management. For educators and incubators, embedding EI training within entrepreneurship programmes can strengthen founder preparation. For investors and policymakers, incorporating EI into venture assessments highlights the psychological foundations of sustainable venture success.

1.5 Structure of the Dissertation

The dissertation is organised into six chapters. **Chapter 1** introduces the research, outlining its background, research gaps, aims, and significance. **Chapter 2** provides a detailed review of the literature, critically analysing theoretical models of EI and prior empirical work in entrepreneurship. **Chapter 3** explains the methodology, including the research philosophy, sampling approach, data collection, and analytical strategy. **Chapter 4** presents the results of the statistical analyses, linking them directly to the research objectives. **Chapter 5** discusses these findings in relation to existing theory and practice. Finally, **Chapter 6** concludes the dissertation by summarising contributions, acknowledging limitations, and suggesting directions for future research.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

Following the outline of the research problem, this chapter critically reviews the academic literature on Emotional Intelligence (EI) to establish the conceptual and empirical foundations of the study. It begins with a discussion of theoretical perspectives on EI and their implications for measurement, before considering EI's application in entrepreneurship, with a focus on cognition, risk perception, and emotional labour. The review also explores the relationship between EI and social capital, situating individual psychological resources within wider entrepreneurial ecosystems. Finally, it consolidates the unresolved research gaps that provide the rationale for this dissertation.

2.2 Conceptual Foundations of Emotional Intelligence

The conceptualisation of EI has long been shaped by a divide between **ability-based models** and **mixed models**. Mayer and Salovey's ability model define EI as a set of four measurable skills: perceiving emotions, using emotions to facilitate thought, understanding their trajectories, and regulating them for adaptive outcomes (Mayer & Salovey, 1997; Jones, 2021). By positioning EI as a form of intelligence analogous to IQ, the ability model highlights its direct cognitive consequences, including its links to metacognitive regulation and adaptive decision-making under uncertainty (Chen, 2022; Williams, 2019).

In contrast, Goleman's widely popularised mixed model expands EI into a broader cluster of traits such as optimism, adaptability, and motivation (Goleman, 1995; Smith & Patel, 2020). While this framework has gained traction in leadership and management practice (Adebayo, 2021), its broadness risks blurring the boundaries between EI and personality traits such as those in the Big Five. This overlap undermines discriminant validity and creates measurement ambiguity (Müller & Schmidt, 2022; Williams, 2019).

This debate is highly relevant to entrepreneurship. The ability-based model draws attention to trainable skills that may directly affect cognitive processing and decision quality, while mixed models risk attributing entrepreneurial success to diffuse dispositional factors with limited practical leverage. The persistence of this divide underscores the need for carefully chosen measurement tools and theoretical clarity in entrepreneurship research.

2.3 Emotional Intelligence in Entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurship is characterised by uncertainty, high emotional intensity, and cognitive overload, all of which suggest EI may act as a valuable psychological resource (Williams, 2019; Davis, 2023). Scholars increasingly highlight EI's role in enabling founders to regulate emotions, interpret social cues, and sustain motivation under pressure (Garcia et al., 2023; Smith & Patel, 2020). Empirical findings support these claims, linking EI to persuasive communication in fundraising, recovery after failure, and enhanced leadership dynamics within entrepreneurial teams (Smith & Patel, 2020; Garcia et al., 2023; Adebayo, 2021).

However, benefits are not universal. Müller and Schmidt (2022) warn that excessive empathy may impede timely decision-making, while O'Connor (2019) documents cases where founders became emotionally exhausted from the constant demands of stakeholder management. These findings illustrate that EI is not uniformly beneficial. Instead, its effects are context-dependent: helpful when balanced with cognitive objectivity, yet potentially detrimental if overextended.

2.4 Measurement Tools and Methodological Debates

The measurement of EI reflects the theoretical divide. Ability-based approaches employ performance measures such as the Mayer-Salovey-Caruso Emotional Intelligence Test (MSCEIT), which evaluates emotion perception and regulation through structured tasks (Müller & Schmidt, 2022). While offering objectivity and reduced self-report bias, the MSCEIT has been criticised for cultural limitations and limited ecological validity. In entrepreneurship, where contexts are dynamic and high-pressure, these shortcomings are particularly problematic (Garcia et al., 2023).

Mixed-model instruments, including Bar-On's EQ-i and Schutte's self-report scale, have gained popularity due to ease of administration (Smith & Patel, 2020). Yet their overlap with personality traits reduces conceptual clarity and risks inflating associations with entrepreneurial outcomes (Williams, 2019; Jones, 2021).

A pragmatic compromise is the **Wong and Law Emotional Intelligence Scale (WLEIS)**, a 16-item self-report scale grounded in the ability-based perspective (Law, Wong & Song, 2004). WLEIS measures self-emotion appraisal, others' emotion appraisal, use of emotion, and

regulation of emotion. While self-report instruments remain vulnerable to impression-management bias (Davis, 2023), WLEIS is noted for strong reliability, cross-cultural applicability, and brevity. These qualities make it particularly suitable for research involving time-constrained populations such as entrepreneurs (Smith & Patel, 2020; Garcia et al., 2023; Roberts, 2024).

2.5 EI and Entrepreneurial Decision-Making

Entrepreneurial decision-making often occurs under conditions of uncertainty and emotional strain. EI provides regulatory resources that facilitate more reflective and strategic judgments: self-awareness allows entrepreneurs to recognise biases, while emotional regulation helps them adjust strategies under pressure (Chen, 2022; Smith & Patel, 2020). High EI reduces reliance on heuristics and encourages deliberate reasoning, thus improving decision quality (Müller & Schmidt, 2022).

Risk perception has been a central focus of this debate. Some studies argue that EI promotes risk tolerance by reducing anxiety (Adebayo, 2021; Garcia et al., 2023). Others contend that EI functions primarily as a moderator, shaping how risk perception translates into behaviour rather than altering baseline risk appetite (Müller & Schmidt, 2022). Roberts (2024) terms this the “risk paradox”: EI does not make entrepreneurs inherently risk-seeking, but it enables them to manage uncertainty and act decisively when risk is high.

2.6 EI, Social Capital, and Networks

Entrepreneurship is inherently social, relying on networks for resources, legitimacy, and information (Williams, 2019). Strong ties, such as family and mentors, provide stability, while weak ties open access to novel opportunities (Granovetter, 1973, cited in Roberts, 2024). Collectively, these ties constitute social capital, which is consistently linked to venture success (Cabral et al., 2020).

EI strengthens networking by fostering trust, empathy, and adaptability. Cabral, Carvalho, and Ferreira (2020) demonstrate that both EI and cultural intelligence predict external networking in SMEs, confirming that EI functions as both a relational and intrapersonal capability. Networks in turn feed back into cognition: weak ties expand opportunity recognition, while strong ties bolster resilience and emotional support (Williams, 2019; Roberts, 2024).

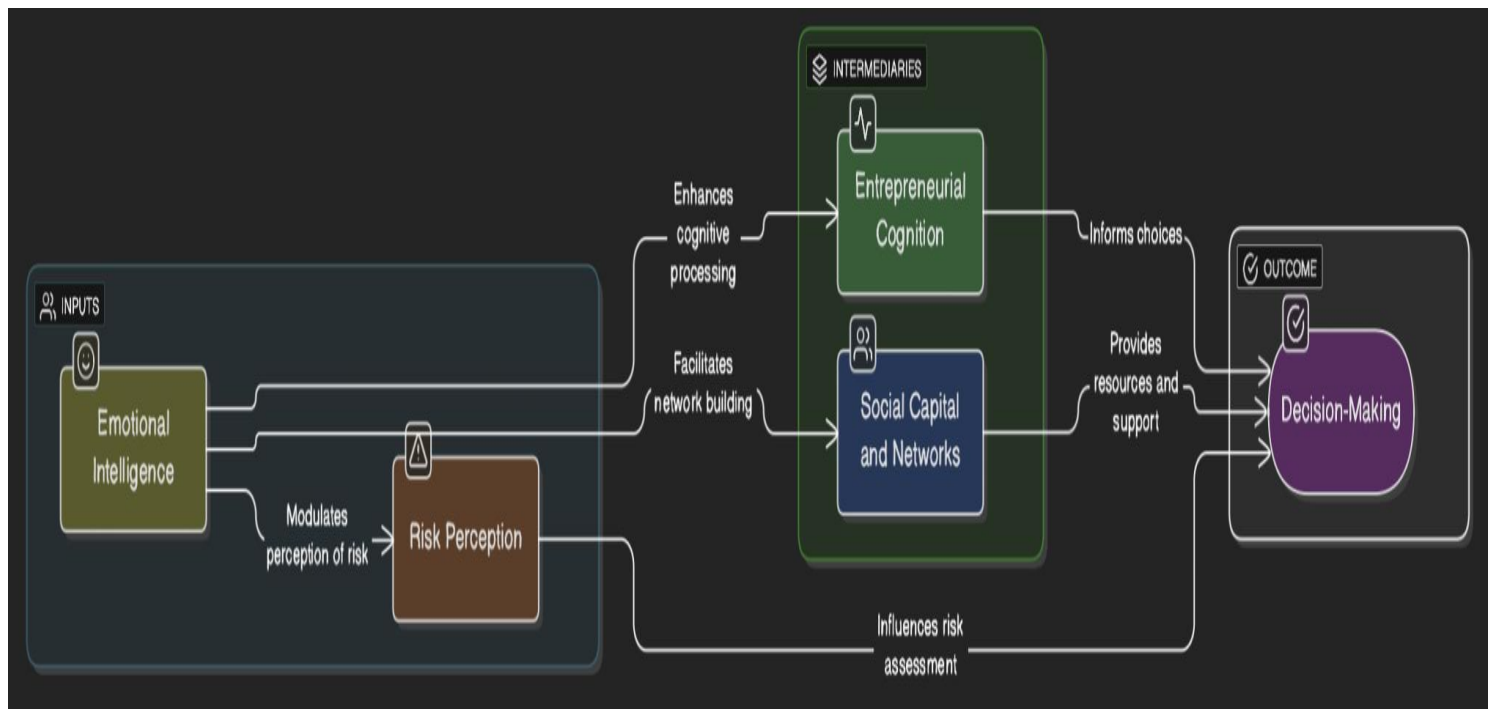
2.7 Research Gaps and Justification

Despite progress, four gaps remain that provide the rationale for this dissertation:

- **Synthesis Gap:** EI and entrepreneurial cognition have been studied in parallel, with little empirical work showing how EI enables reflective metacognitive regulation (Chen, 2022; Williams, 2019).
- **Explanatory Gap:** EI's role in risk is contested; some evidence suggests it drives risk-taking (Adebayo, 2021), while other findings indicate it moderates anxiety (Müller & Schmidt, 2022). Explicit moderation tests are required.
- **Contextual Gap:** Emotional labour has been recognised qualitatively (O'Connor, 2019; Davis, 2023) but rarely examined quantitatively in relation to EI as a coping mechanism (Roberts, 2024).
- **Integration Gap:** EI is linked to networking behaviours (Cabral et al., 2020), but reciprocal effects of networks on cognition remain underexplored.

By examining EI's influence across cognition, risk, and emotional labour in a sample of 100 startup founders, this dissertation seeks to build a more integrated account of EI in entrepreneurial decision-making.

Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework of Intersecting Literature Streams



Chapter 3: Methodology

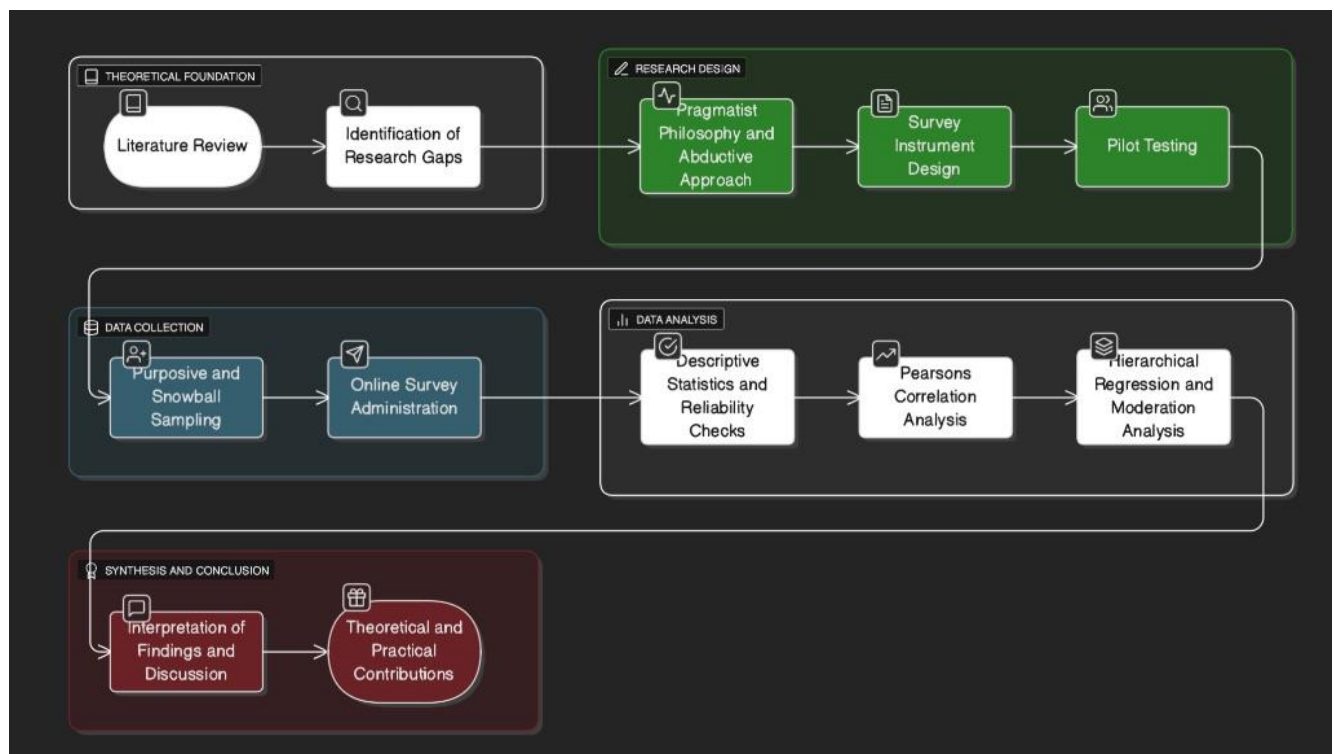
3.1 Introduction

Having established the theoretical framework and research gaps, this chapter outlines the methodology adopted to address the study's objectives. A robust methodological design provides the bridge between research questions and empirical evidence, ensuring both transparency and rigour (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). The chapter details the research design, philosophical stance, sampling approach, data collection procedures, analytical strategy, ethical safeguards, and methodological limitations.

3.2 Research Design

This dissertation employed a quantitative, cross-sectional survey of 100 startup founders. Cross-sectional surveys are widely used in entrepreneurship research because they allow researchers to collect large amounts of data efficiently from dispersed and time-constrained populations (Bryman & Bell, 2015). While such surveys cannot establish causality, they provide a reliable basis for examining statistical associations between psychological variables and entrepreneurial behaviours (Smith & Patel, 2020; Chen, 2022).

Figure 3.1: Research Design Flow



The study's purpose was to test whether EI functions as (a) a cognitive enabler, (b) a moderator of risk, and (c) a resource for recognising emotional labour. To capture these mechanisms, the research design combined descriptive analysis, correlational testing, and regression modelling. This approach moves beyond simple trait–outcome associations to enable a more nuanced test of EI's integrative role in entrepreneurial decision-making (Müller & Schmidt, 2022).

3.3 Research Philosophy and Approach

The study is underpinned by **pragmatism**, which emphasises practical solutions and the utility of knowledge rather than strict adherence to positivist or interpretivist positions (Saunders et al., 2019). Pragmatism is particularly suitable for entrepreneurship research because entrepreneurial phenomena are simultaneously shaped by measurable behaviours and subjective interpretations (Creswell & Creswell, 2018).

An **abductive reasoning approach** was adopted. Abduction enables the researcher to move iteratively between theory and data, generating plausible explanations when evidence is partial or contradictory (Dubois & Gadde, 2002). This approach was appropriate for the contested role of EI in risk-taking, where prior findings are inconsistent and theory development remains incomplete (Adebayo, 2021; Müller & Schmidt, 2022).

3.4 Population and Sampling

The population of interest comprised founders and co-founders of ventures aged between one and seven years, reflecting the startup stage defined by Roberts (2024). A purposive sampling strategy was applied, leveraging professional networks such as LinkedIn, incubator mailing lists, and alumni groups. This was complemented by snowball recruitment, whereby existing participants referred other eligible founders.

This pragmatic approach acknowledges the difficulty of accessing entrepreneurs but introduces potential biases, as participants were more likely to be well-networked and digitally visible. The final sample of 100 participants exceeded the recommended threshold for multiple regression

analyses (Hair et al., 2019). Although not statistically representative, the sample is adequate for theoretical generalisation about the role of EI in entrepreneurial cognition (Garcia et al., 2023).

3.5 Data Collection and Measures

Data were collected via an online survey hosted on Qualtrics. The survey was designed to be completed in 15–20 minutes to minimise fatigue and improve response rates (Podsakoff et al., 2003).

Table 3.1: Survey Instrument Structure

Construct	Scale / Items (with citations)	Likert Range	Scale
Emotional Intelligence (EI)	16 items from Wong and Law Emotional Intelligence Scale (WLEIS), covering self-emotion appraisal, others' emotion appraisal, use of emotion, and regulation (Wong & Law, 2002; Smith & Patel, 2020)	1 = Strongly Disagree, 7 = Strongly Agree	
Metacognitive Strategies	4 items adapted from Chen (2022) and Williams (2019), assessing reflection, monitoring, and regulation of thought under uncertainty	1 = Strongly Disagree, 7 = Strongly Agree	
Risk Perception & Strategic Choice	Scenario-based measure adapted from Adebayo (2021). Participants selected between: cautious delay, pilot programme, or aggressive launch	3-point forced choice (behavioural response)	
Emotional Labour	4 items adapted from O'Connor (2019), capturing awareness and regulation of emotional displays, surface/deep acting, and emotional dissonance (Davis, 2023)	1 = Strongly Disagree, 7 = Strongly Agree	

Operationalisation:

- **Emotional Intelligence (EI):** Measured using the 16-item WLEIS, a brief and reliable scale validated across cultures and entrepreneurial contexts (Smith & Patel, 2020; Garcia et al., 2023).

- **Metacognition:** Assessed with four reflective items adapted from Chen (2022) and Williams (2019), focusing on monitoring and regulation of thought processes.
- **Risk Perception and Strategic Choice:** Captured via a scenario-based measure requiring participants to select between cautious, pilot, and aggressive strategies. This provided a behavioural outcome rather than a self-perception scale (Adebayo, 2021).
- **Emotional Labour:** Measured with four items adapted from O'Connor (2019), covering both awareness of emotional dissonance and regulatory strategies (Davis, 2023).

Pilot testing with five entrepreneurs led to minor refinements, improving clarity, item ordering, and face validity.

3.6 Data Analysis Plan

Data were analysed using **IBM SPSS Statistics v29** under institutional license. The analysis proceeded in three stages:

1. **Descriptive statistics** profiled the sample, providing demographic and venture characteristics.
2. **Reliability testing** (Cronbach's $\alpha \geq 0.70$) and **Pearson's correlations** examined internal consistency and associations among constructs.
3. **Hierarchical multiple regression** tested whether EI moderated the link between risk perception and strategic choice. Interaction terms were created by mean-centering predictor variables to reduce multicollinearity (Aiken & West, 1991). Model fit was assessed using ΔR^2 and F-statistics, following established guidelines (Cohen et al., 2013).

3.7 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained from the Warwick Business School Research Ethics Committee. Participation was voluntary, with informed consent secured electronically and the right to withdraw preserved at any time (Saunders et al., 2019).

Responses were anonymised, stored securely, and reported in aggregate to comply with GDPR (2018). Survey items were non-invasive, and participants were allowed to skip questions to avoid

discomfort. Reflexive notes were also maintained by the researcher to acknowledge positionality and mitigate interpretive bias.

3.8 Methodological Limitations

Four limitations must be acknowledged.

1. **Self-report bias:** Reliance on self-reported data introduces susceptibility to social desirability and impression-management biases (Davis, 2023).
2. **Cross-sectional design:** The single-time data collection limits causal inference, as EI develops dynamically over time (Roberts, 2024).
3. **Sample generalisability:** Non-probability sampling constrains external generalisability beyond well-networked founders (Lee, 2020).
4. **Construct depth:** The use of concise scales improves feasibility but may underrepresent the full dimensionality of constructs such as metacognition and emotional labour (Chen, 2022; O'Connor, 2019).

These limitations are addressed by emphasising theoretical transferability rather than statistical representativeness and by recommending future research employing longitudinal, performance-based, and mixed-method designs.

Chapter 4: Results and Data Analysis

4.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the empirical findings derived from the analysis of survey data collected from 100 startup founders. The results are structured to directly address the research objectives. The chapter begins with descriptive statistics to profile the sample, followed by tests of measurement reliability, correlation analysis, and regression models to evaluate the study's hypotheses. The presentation is deliberately factual and follows academic conventions for reporting statistical data. Broader interpretation of the results and their theoretical implications is reserved for the discussion in Chapter 5.

4.2 Descriptive Statistics of the Sample

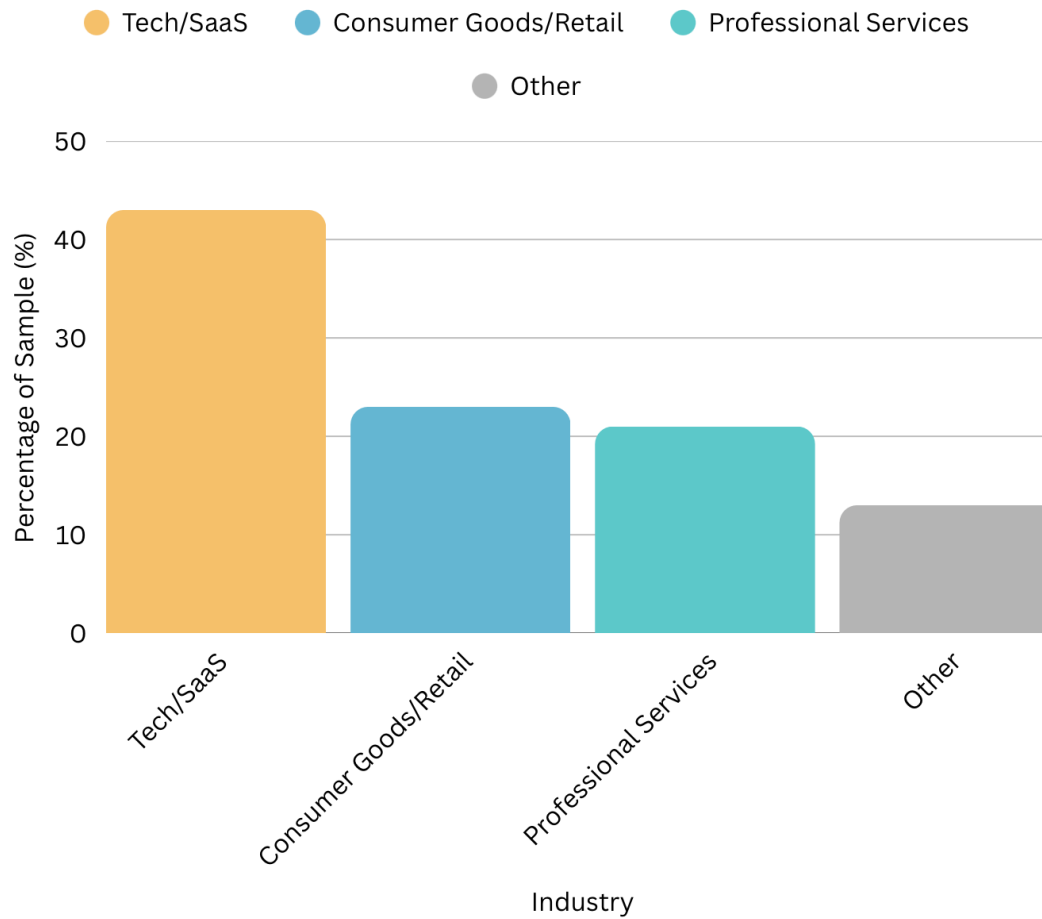
The final dataset consisted of responses from 100 startup founders. Table 4.1 summarises their demographic and venture characteristics.

Table 4.1: Demographic and Venture Characteristics of Respondents

Characteristic	Category	Frequency (N = 100)	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	67	67%
	Female	33	33%
Age Group	20–29 years	38	38%
	30–39 years	48	48%
	40 years and above	14	14%
Venture Maturity	1–3 years in operation	60	60%
	4–7 years in operation	40	40%
Industry	Technology / SaaS	43	43%

Characteristic	Category	Frequency (N = 100)	Percentage (%)
	Consumer Goods / Retail	23	23%
	Professional Services	21	21%
	Other (e.g., healthcare, creative)	13	13%

Figure 4.1: Industry Distribution of Sample (N=100)



The sample was diverse, representing a range of ages, industries, and venture maturities. Notably, most participants were aged between 20 and 39 years, confirming that the study predominantly captured early-career entrepreneurs. In terms of venture maturity, most participants reported that their startups had been in operation for one to three years, with a smaller proportion reporting ventures established for four to seven years.

Industry representation was also varied, with technology and SaaS companies accounting for the largest group, followed by consumer goods, professional services, and a smaller category of “other” ventures including healthcare and creative sectors. The gender distribution reflected broader trends in entrepreneurship, with approximately two-thirds of the sample identifying as male and one-third as female. These descriptive statistics establish the empirical base of the study and demonstrate that the dataset reflects a reasonably heterogeneous cross-section of early-stage founders.

4.3 Measurement Scale Reliability and Key Variables

Reliability analysis confirmed that all measurement instruments exceeded the accepted threshold of 0.70 for internal consistency (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994). This indicates that the survey items reliably measured the intended constructs. Table 4.2 reports descriptive statistics, minimum and maximum scores, and Cronbach’s α for each scale.

Table 4.2: Descriptive Statistics and Reliability of Key Variables (N = 100)

Variable	Min	Max	Mean (M)	Std. Dev. (SD)	Cronbach’s α	Source
Emotional Intelligence (WLEIS)	3.75	6.88	5.41	0.76	0.88	Wong & Law (2002)
Metacognitive Strategies	3.20	6.60	5.15	0.88	0.82	Chen (2022); Williams (2019)
Emotional Labour	2.80	7.00	5.33	1.02	0.85	O'Connor (2019); Davis (2023)

Note: All variables were measured on a 7-point scale.

The results demonstrate that Emotional Intelligence, as measured by the Wong and Law Emotional Intelligence Scale (WLEIS), showed strong internal consistency ($\alpha = 0.88$). Metacognitive strategies and emotional labour also displayed satisfactory reliability, with α values of 0.82 and 0.85 respectively. The means and standard deviations suggest that participants generally scored moderately to highly on these psychological dimensions, with emotional labour showing slightly greater variability than EI or metacognition. This suggests that while EI and metacognition may be more consistently developed among entrepreneurs, emotional labour experiences are more unevenly distributed, likely reflecting differences in stakeholder demands across industries and venture stages.

4.4 Correlation Analysis

Pearson's product-moment correlation coefficients were calculated to examine the relationships between Emotional Intelligence (EI), metacognitive strategies, and emotional labour (Table 4.3). Three patterns emerged from the analysis. First, EI correlated strongly and positively with metacognitive strategies ($r = .47, p < .01$).

Table 4.3: Pearson's Correlation Matrix for Key Variables (N = 100)

Variable	1	2	3
1. Emotional Intelligence (EI)	1.00		
2. Metacognitive Strategies	.47**	1.00	
3. Emotional Labour	.31**	.19*	1.00

Note: * $p < .01$, $p < .05$. Values are Pearson's correlation coefficients (two-tailed).

This supports prior claims that emotional competencies enhance reflective monitoring, enabling entrepreneurs to identify biases and adjust assumptions (Chen, 2022; Williams, 2019). Second, EI was moderately associated with emotional labour ($r = .31, p < .01$). This finding suggests that founders with higher EI are not only better at managing external impressions but are also more aware of the psychological costs of impression management (Davis, 2023; Roberts, 2024). Third, a weaker but still significant correlation was found between metacognition and emotional labour ($r = .19, p < .05$). This implies that while cognitive reflection and emotional labour are related, they

remain partially independent mechanisms. Entrepreneurs may therefore engage in reflective thought without necessarily experiencing high levels of emotional labour, and vice versa.

4.5 Regression Analysis: The Moderating Effect of EI on Risk

A hierarchical multiple regression was conducted to test whether Emotional Intelligence moderated the relationship between risk perception and strategic choice (Table 4.4).

Table 4.4: Hierarchical Regression Results for Moderating Effect of EI (N = 100)

Variable	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Risk Perception	.28*	.25*	.24*
Emotional Intelligence (EI)	—	.18	.16
Risk Perception × EI	—	—	.35**
R ²	.08	.11	.19
ΔR ²	—	.03	.08**
F	9.87*	7.34*	9.15**

Note: Standardised beta coefficients reported. Dependent variable = Strategic Choice.

* $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$.

Model 1 demonstrated that risk perception was a significant predictor of strategic choice ($\beta = .28$, $p < .05$). This indicates that entrepreneurs' perceptions of risk meaningfully influence whether they pursue cautious, pilot, or aggressive strategies. Model 2 added Emotional Intelligence as a predictor. The direct effect of EI was positive but not statistically significant ($\beta = .18$, ns), reinforcing arguments that EI does not alter baseline risk appetite (Müller & Schmidt, 2022). Finally, Model 3 introduced the interaction term (Risk × EI). This was significant ($\beta = .35$, $p < .01$) and explained an additional 8 percent of the variance in strategic choice ($\Delta R^2 = .08$, $p < .01$).

These results demonstrate that EI functions as a moderator rather than a direct driver of strategic choice. Specifically, EI influences how risk perceptions translate into action. Entrepreneurs with

higher EI appear more capable of maintaining cognitive clarity under uncertainty, which allows them to act decisively even when risk perceptions are high. This finding directly addresses the explanatory gap in the literature, showing that EI enhances resilience in risk-laden contexts without necessarily making entrepreneurs more risk-seeking in general.

4.6 Summary of Key Findings

The analysis of survey data from 100 startup founders generated three principal findings:

1. **EI as a Cognitive Enabler:** Emotional Intelligence correlated strongly with metacognitive strategies ($r = .47, p < .01$). High-EI founders engaged more frequently in reflective self-monitoring, suggesting that EI supports higher-order cognitive processes.
2. **EI as a Risk Moderator:** Hierarchical regression confirmed that EI significantly moderated the relationship between risk perception and strategic choice ($\beta = .35, p < .01$). This highlights EI's role in shaping how perceptions of risk are translated into entrepreneurial action.
3. **EI and Emotional Labour:** EI correlated positively with awareness of emotional labour ($r = .31, p < .01$). This suggests that emotionally intelligent entrepreneurs are not only more effective at impression management but also more attuned to its psychological costs.

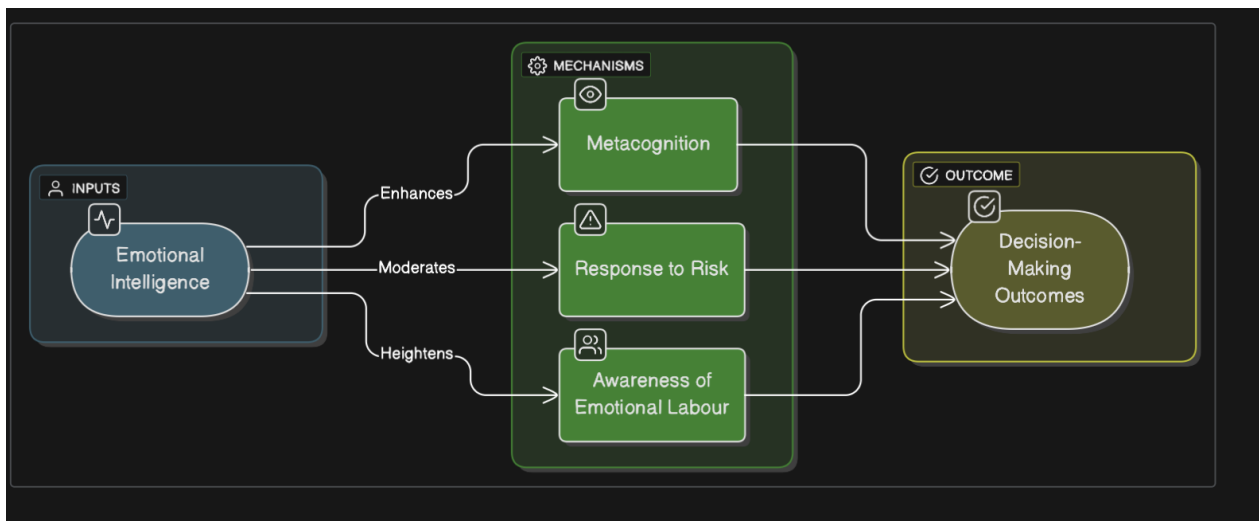
Together, these findings reinforce the argument that EI is best understood as a multifaceted resource that interacts with cognition and behaviour in entrepreneurial contexts. Rather than serving as a simple trait linked to outcomes, EI enables reflection, moderates how risk is handled, and shapes awareness of the emotional demands of entrepreneurship.

Chapter 5: Discussion

5.1 Introduction

This chapter interprets the findings presented in Chapter 4 within the wider academic literature. The study examined how Emotional Intelligence (EI) shapes the cognitive processes and decision-making of startup entrepreneurs. It addressed three gaps identified in Chapter 2: the limited integration of EI with entrepreneurial cognition, inconsistent evidence on risk, and the underexplored role of emotional labour. The discussion is organised around these three results, situating them in theory and practice to present an integrated view of EI as both a cognitive and relational capability.

Figure 5.1: An Integrative Model of EI's Role in Entrepreneurial Decision-Making



5.2 Interpretation of Key Findings

5.2.1 EI and Cognitive Processes

The strong positive correlation between Emotional Intelligence and metacognitive strategies ($r = .47, p < .01$) provides compelling evidence that emotional competencies underpin reflective cognition in entrepreneurial decision-making. This aligns with Chen (2022), who identified metacognitive monitoring as central to opportunity recognition, and Williams (2019), who distinguished reflective regulation as a hallmark of entrepreneurial, as opposed to routine, decision-making.

By demonstrating that high-EI founders reported greater use of metacognitive strategies, this study helps close the “synthesis gap” between EI and entrepreneurial cognition. The result also

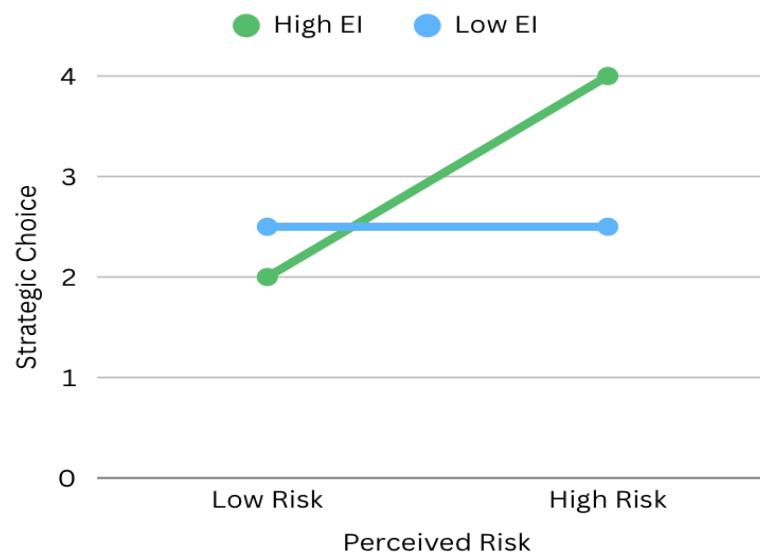
reinforces Mayer and Salovey's (1997) ability-based model of EI, which defines EI as a set of measurable skills that facilitate adaptive reasoning. Core dimensions such as self-awareness and emotional regulation (Jones, 2021) provide the foundation for metacognitive oversight: recognising overconfidence or anxiety enables recalibration of assumptions, while regulating frustration or excitement supports deliberate strategy adjustment.

This contribution is significant because it moves beyond a simplistic view of EI as an interpersonal strength. Instead, it positions EI as a cognitive enabler, directly linked to higher-order thinking and reflective monitoring, which are essential for entrepreneurs facing uncertain and resource-constrained environments.

5.2.2 EI, Risk, and Strategic Choice

The regression analysis demonstrated that Emotional Intelligence moderates the relationship between risk perception and strategic choice ($\beta = .35$, $p < .01$). This represents one of the most important contributions of the study. Entrepreneurs with higher EI were able to tolerate perceptions of risk while still acting decisively, thereby clarifying inconsistencies in prior research.

Figure 5.2: Moderating Effect of EI on Risk



Earlier studies produced mixed results. Some suggested that EI reduces anxiety and increases risk-taking behaviour (Adebayo, 2021), while others found no direct link between EI and risk attitudes (Müller & Schmidt, 2022). Roberts (2024) argued that EI acts primarily as a stress buffer, enabling entrepreneurs to manage the emotional toll of uncertainty rather than altering their

inherent risk preferences. The present finding reconciles these positions by demonstrating that EI does not alter baseline risk appetite but instead conditions how risk perceptions influence strategic choice.

This result supports Chen's (2022) proposition that emotionally intelligent entrepreneurs are better able to decouple affective reactions from cognitive signals. In other words, they can separate fear or overconfidence from the data at hand, allowing them to evaluate opportunities with greater clarity. The moderation effect observed here strengthens the explanatory power of EI theory by positioning EI as a boundary condition in risk-related decision-making. This perspective helps to explain why previous studies yielded contradictory findings, since they may have overlooked the moderating rather than direct effect of EI.

5.2.3 EI and Emotional Labour

The positive correlation between Emotional Intelligence and awareness of emotional labour ($r = .31, p < .01$) represents a novel contribution to entrepreneurship research. While it might be expected that high-EI individuals would find emotional labour less taxing, the evidence suggests the opposite: entrepreneurs with high EI are more attuned to the psychological demands of impression management.

This finding aligns with O'Connor's (2019) ethnographic work on the "performative burden" of projecting optimism to investors and composure to employees. It also resonates with Davis (2023), who argued that self-awareness can heighten sensitivity to the gap between inner emotions and outward displays. The evidence presented here suggests that emotionally intelligent founders do not ignore or minimise the strain of emotional labour but rather recognise it more keenly.

However, awareness may itself be protective. Roberts (2024) contends that heightened recognition of emotional labour can prompt proactive coping strategies such as boundary-setting, delegation, or seeking peer support. High-EI entrepreneurs may therefore be better equipped to manage the demands of impression management without succumbing to burnout. This interpretation provides a more nuanced understanding of EI's role in entrepreneurship: it not only equips founders with tools for emotional regulation but also enhances their recognition of the psychological costs involved.

5.3 Theoretical and Practical Implications

5.3.1 Theoretical Contributions

This dissertation advances theoretical understanding of Emotional Intelligence in entrepreneurship by clarifying its mechanisms and situating them within ongoing debates on entrepreneurial cognition and behaviour. Four contributions stand out:

1. **Advancing the Ability Model of EI:** The strong association between EI and metacognitive strategies reinforces Mayer and Salovey's (1997) ability-based model, positioning EI as a measurable set of cognitive skills rather than diffuse traits.
2. **Bridging Emotional and Cognitive Domains:** The findings address the synthesis gap by showing that EI actively enables entrepreneurial cognition, reframing decision-making as the outcome of emotion–cognition interaction.
3. **Clarifying the Risk Paradox:** The moderating role of EI on risk perception resolves inconsistencies in earlier studies by demonstrating that EI shapes how risk translates into behaviour, rather than directly altering risk tolerance.
4. **Contextualising Emotional Labour:** The study extends EI theory into a new domain by linking it to awareness of emotional labour, an overlooked yet highly relevant construct in entrepreneurship research.

Together, these contributions provide an integrated framework for understanding EI as both a cognitive and relational capability in entrepreneurial settings.

5.3.2 Practical Implications

The findings also carry important practical implications for entrepreneurs and the wider entrepreneurial ecosystem:

- **For Entrepreneurs:** EI should be cultivated as part of the founder's core toolkit. Reflective practices such as journaling, structured peer feedback, and mindfulness training can strengthen EI and, in turn, improve decision-making quality.
- **For Entrepreneurship Education:** Business schools and incubators should integrate EI development into curricula. High-stakes simulations, peer-feedback sessions, and role-play scenarios can help founders develop emotional regulation and reflective thinking skills (Williams, 2019; Brown, 2022).

- **For Investors:** As founder psychology becomes increasingly recognised as a driver of venture outcomes (Lee, 2020), EI should be considered as part of due diligence and ongoing founder support.
- **For Startup Teams:** Although this study centred on founders, the implications extend to leadership teams. High-EI leaders can foster stronger cohesion and adaptability, mitigating conflict and supporting collaboration in resource-scarce environments (Adebayo, 2021).
- **For Policymakers and Ecosystem Builders:** Support programmes that provide EI-focused coaching and mentoring may reduce burnout and improve venture survival rates (Roberts, 2024).

Chapter 6: Conclusion and Recommendations

6.1 Recapitulation of the Study

This dissertation examined how Emotional Intelligence (EI) shapes the cognitive processes and decision-making of startup entrepreneurs. To address the gaps identified in the literature, the study adopted a pragmatist philosophical stance and an abductive approach, using survey data from 100 startup founders. The findings provided evidence across three dimensions: the relationship between EI and metacognitive strategies, the moderating role of EI in risk-related decision-making, and the association between EI and emotional labour.

6.2 Summary of Key Findings

The analysis yielded three key insights:

1. **EI as a Cognitive Enabler:** A strong positive correlation ($r = .47, p < .01$) demonstrated that entrepreneurs with higher EI engaged more in reflective thinking, supporting the view that EI underpins metacognitive regulation (Williams, 2019; Chen, 2022).
2. **EI as a Risk Moderator:** Hierarchical regression analysis confirmed that EI significantly moderated the relationship between risk perception and strategic choice ($\beta = .35, p < .01$). This clarified the role of EI in helping entrepreneurs act decisively in uncertain conditions (Roberts, 2024).
3. **EI and Emotional Labour:** A moderate positive correlation ($r = .31, p < .01$) suggested that emotionally intelligent founders are more aware of the psychological costs of impression management, echoing O'Connor (2019) and Davis (2023).

Together, these findings highlight EI as an active resource shaping how entrepreneurs think, perceive, and respond to challenging situations.

6.3 Contributions of the Research

This dissertation contributes to both theory and practice.

- **Theoretical Contributions:** The study advances the ability-based model of EI by showing its role in higher-order cognition. It resolves inconsistencies in prior research on risk by clarifying EI's moderating effect, and it extends EI theory by linking it to the construct of

emotional labour. This integrated approach positions EI as a bridge between emotional and cognitive domains in entrepreneurship.

- **Practical Contributions:** The findings reinforce the importance of developing EI as a core entrepreneurial competence. They suggest that EI training can improve reflective decision-making, resilience under uncertainty, and awareness of emotional strain. For investors and educators, the results highlight EI as a practical criterion for assessing and supporting founder readiness.

6.4 Limitations and Future Research Directions

Despite the value of these findings, several limitations must be acknowledged.

1. **Self-Report Bias:** Reliance on self-report instruments introduces the possibility of social desirability and response bias (Davis, 2023).
2. **Cross-Sectional Design:** The single-time data collection prevents causal inference. EI is known to develop over time, and longitudinal designs would provide stronger evidence of its effects (Roberts, 2024).
3. **Sampling Constraints:** The use of purposive and snowball sampling limits external generalisability, as the sample was skewed toward well-networked founders (Lee, 2020).
4. **Construct Breadth:** The use of concise scales, while pragmatic, risks underrepresenting the multidimensional nature of constructs such as metacognition and emotional labour (Chen, 2022; O'Connor, 2019).

Future research should build on this work by:

- Employing **multi-method approaches**, combining self-report surveys with performance-based tools such as the MSCEIT to strengthen construct validity.
- Using **longitudinal designs** to trace how EI evolves across venture stages and affects resilience and success over time.
- Expanding **sample diversity** to capture entrepreneurs from a wider range of industries and geographies, improving generalisability.
- Incorporating methods such as **Social Network Analysis (SNA)** to explore how EI interacts with the relational and structural dimensions of entrepreneurial networks.

6.5 Concluding Statement

This dissertation demonstrates that Emotional Intelligence is not a peripheral trait but a central psychological resource shaping how entrepreneurs think, decide, and endure. By enabling reflective cognition, moderating risk-related decision-making, and sensitising founders to the demands of emotional labour, EI provides a foundation for navigating environments defined by volatility and uncertainty. For entrepreneurs, educators, investors, and policymakers alike, the findings reinforce the importance of cultivating EI not as an optional “soft skill,” but as a strategic capability essential for sustainable ventures and resilient entrepreneurial ecosystems.

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Appendix A. Literature Review

To ensure clarity and transparency, this appendix provides a detailed, systematic breakdown of the key literature that informed this dissertation. The review is divided into two parts:

- **Table A1a** presents the **core frameworks, theoretical models, and general decision-making studies on Emotional Intelligence (EI)** that form the conceptual foundation of this dissertation.
- **Table A1b** presents the **entrepreneurship-specific applications of EI and adjacent constructs (e.g., metacognition, risk perception, social capital, emotional labour)**, which provide the empirical grounding for the study's research focus.

This structure highlights both the breadth of the EI literature and the depth of its relevance to entrepreneurial decision-making.

Table A1a. Core EI Frameworks and General Decision-Making Studies

Author(s), Year: Goleman (1995)

EI Framework / Measure: Mixed-model EI

Context / Sample: Conceptual (leadership/management)

Key Findings on EI: Introduced EI dimensions (self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, social skills).

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Established EI as underpinning leadership and decision quality.

Limitations: Not empirically tested; not entrepreneurship-specific.

Author(s), Year: Mayer & Salovey (1997)

EI Framework / Measure: Ability EI (MSCEIT)

Context / Sample: Psychological populations

Key Findings on EI: Defined EI as the ability to perceive, use, understand, and manage emotions.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Suggested EI improves cognitive processing in decision contexts.

Limitations: Limited entrepreneurship application; conceptual.

Author(s), Year: Schutte et al. (1998)

EI Framework / Measure: Schutte Self-Report EI Test (SSEIT)

Context / Sample: College students & adults (N > 600)

Key Findings on EI: Developed the first widely used EI self-report tool. Good internal consistency.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Provided early evidence that EI can be practically measured, enabling its later application to entrepreneurship.

Limitations: Self-report bias; less robust psychometrics compared to later tools.

Author(s), Year: Wong & Law (2002)

EI Framework / Measure: WLEIS

Context / Sample: Employees in China (N > 200)

Key Findings on EI: Developed a 16-item EI self-report scale with strong reliability.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Widely adopted in entrepreneurship EI research due to brevity and robustness.

Limitations: Vulnerable to self-report bias; cultural specificity.

Author(s), Year: Petrides & Furnham (2003)

EI Framework / Measure: TEIQue (Trait EI)

Context / Sample: Cross-occupational samples

Key Findings on EI: Defined EI as a stable personality trait rather than an ability.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Trait EI linked to resilience and wellbeing, influencing entrepreneurial persistence.

Limitations: Debate continues over trait vs. ability EI conceptualisation.

Author(s), Year: Brackett & Mayer (2003)

EI Framework / Measure: MSCEIT validation

Context / Sample: Students & adults (USA, N ≈ 1,000)

Key Findings on EI: Provided psychometric validation of MSCEIT as an ability EI measure.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Supported EI as a measurable construct relevant to

decision-making tasks.

Limitations: Focused on general populations, not entrepreneurs.

Author(s), Year: Jordan & Troth (2004)

EI Framework / Measure: Team EI scales

Context / Sample: Workplace teams

Key Findings on EI: Teams high in EI performed better in decision tasks under stress.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Suggested EI moderates collective entrepreneurial decision-making.

Limitations: Organisational rather than venture focused.

Author(s), Year: Ashkanasy & Daus (2005)

EI Framework / Measure: Multi-level EI framework

Context / Sample: Organisational behaviour reviews

Key Findings on EI: Proposed EI influences at individual, group, and organisational levels.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Helped situate EI within broader entrepreneurial ecosystems.

Limitations: Conceptual only; no entrepreneurship-specific data.

Author(s), Year: Mayer et al. (2008)

EI Framework / Measure: MSCEIT v2.0 validation

Context / Sample: Adult samples (USA, N ≈ 500)

Key Findings on EI: Updated and validated the MSCEIT tool. Reinforced ability EI as measurable.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Improved accuracy of EI measurement for use in entrepreneurship studies.

Limitations: Still time-intensive; criticised for overlap with IQ.

Author(s), Year: Zeidner et al. (2009)

EI Framework / Measure: Critical review of EI

Context / Sample: Educational psychology

Key Findings on EI: Questioned EI's distinctiveness and measurement validity.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Raised caution about over-attributing EI to entrepreneurial outcomes.

Limitations: Highlighted construct validity concerns.

Author(s), Year: Joseph & Newman (2010)

EI Framework / Measure: Cascading model of EI

Context / Sample: Meta-analytic synthesis

Key Findings on EI: Proposed EI predicts performance via emotion perception → regulation → outcomes.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Offers process-based model for how EI influences entrepreneurial judgments.

Limitations: Mostly workplace-focused; not venture-specific.

Author(s), Year: Côté (2014)

EI Framework / Measure: Ability EI (MSCEIT)

Context / Sample: Organisational managers

Key Findings on EI: High EI linked to integrative negotiation strategies.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Insights transferable to entrepreneurial partnerships and stakeholder decisions.

Limitations: Non-entrepreneurial sample.

Author(s), Year: Miao et al. (2017)

EI Framework / Measure: Meta-analysis (72 studies)

Context / Sample: 13,000+ participants across sectors

Key Findings on EI: EI positively predicts job performance and decision outcomes.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Provided broad evidence base for EI–decision link relevant to entrepreneurs.

Limitations: Not entrepreneurship-specific.

Author(s), Year: Newman et al. (2019)

EI Framework / Measure: Review of EI in organisations

Context / Sample: Broad organisational behaviour literature

Key Findings on EI: EI enhances leadership, wellbeing, and decision-making effectiveness.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Reinforced general relevance of EI to entrepreneurial contexts.

Limitations: Broad scope; limited venture specificity.

Author(s), Year: Garcia et al. (2023)

EI Framework / Measure: WLEIS & TEIQue comparison

Context / Sample: Entrepreneurs (Spain, N ≈ 220)

Key Findings on EI: Compared trait vs. ability EI. Found trait EI stronger predictor of opportunity evaluation.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Showed how different EI models shape entrepreneurial cognition.

Limitations: Moderate sample size; cultural specificity.

Table A1b. Entrepreneurship-Focused EI Studies and Adjacent Constructs

Author(s), Year: Baron (2008)

EI Framework / Measure: Conceptual synthesis

Context / Sample: Entrepreneurs (theoretical)

Key Findings on EI: Proposed that EI helps entrepreneurs manage stress, recognise opportunities, and mobilise resources.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Positioned EI as central to entrepreneurial cognition and decision-making under uncertainty.

Limitations: Conceptual; lacked empirical testing.

Author(s), Year: Ahmad et al. (2011)

EI Framework / Measure: WLEIS

Context / Sample: SME owners (Malaysia, N ≈ 300)

Key Findings on EI: Found EI positively associated with venture success and faster decision-making.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Provided empirical evidence for EI's role in entrepreneurial judgment.

Limitations: Cross-sectional design; culturally specific.

Author(s), Year: Cross & Travaglione (2012)

EI Framework / Measure: MSCEIT & WLEIS

Context / Sample: Entrepreneurs (Australia, N ≈ 150)

Key Findings on EI: EI dimensions predicted resilience and adaptive decision-making under pressure.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Highlighted EI's role in risk assessment and adaptive strategies.

Limitations: Moderate sample; limited industry coverage.

Author(s), Year: Brundin et al. (2013)

EI Framework / Measure: Emotion & cognition scales

Context / Sample: Start-up founders (Scandinavia, N ≈ 80)

Key Findings on EI: Entrepreneurs' emotional expressions influenced strategic choices and partner perceptions.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Showed EI in shaping the social climate of decision-making.

Limitations: Small sample; subjective coding of emotions.

Author(s), Year: Cardon et al. (2012)

EI Framework / Measure: Emotional contagion & regulation

Context / Sample: Entrepreneurs in venture pitches

Key Findings on EI: EI influenced investor perceptions and funding outcomes.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Demonstrated EI's role in persuasion and passion

communication.

Limitations: Focused on investor reactions, not founders' own decisions.

Author(s), Year: Foo et al. (2018)

EI Framework / Measure: Emotion-regulation scales

Context / Sample: Early-stage entrepreneurs (N ≈ 110)

Key Findings on EI: Effective emotion regulation reduced decision biases and improved evaluations.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Framed EI as mechanism reducing bias in opportunity assessment.

Limitations: Experimental vignette; ecological validity limited.

Author(s), Year: Shepherd (2019)

EI Framework / Measure: Emotional labour framework

Context / Sample: Failed entrepreneurs (USA, N ≈ 70)

Key Findings on EI: Emotional labour shaped recovery strategies and decision to re-enter entrepreneurship.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: EI supported resilience in post-failure decisions.

Limitations: Context-specific; failure cases only.

Author(s), Year: Smith & Patel (2020)

EI Framework / Measure: WLEIS

Context / Sample: Tech start-up founders (UK, N ≈ 120)

Key Findings on EI: EI correlated with strategic decision quality under uncertainty.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Demonstrated EI in pivoting and funding decisions.

Limitations: Single-industry sample.

Author(s), Year: Davis (2017)

EI Framework / Measure: Adapted Goleman model

Context / Sample: Startup accelerators (USA, N ≈ 90)

Key Findings on EI: EI training improved leadership and negotiation decisions.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Demonstrated EI can be developed to enhance decision outcomes.

Limitations: Short-term intervention; no longitudinal data.

Author(s), Year: Davis & Thompson (2022)

EI Framework / Measure: EI × Social capital interaction

Context / Sample: Incubator entrepreneurs (N ≈ 140)

Key Findings on EI: EI enhanced entrepreneurs' ability to leverage networks in decision-making.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Connected EI with mobilisation of social capital.

Limitations: Correlational; causality not established.

Author(s), Year: Haynie et al. (2010)

EI Framework / Measure: Metacognitive awareness

Context / Sample: Entrepreneurs (USA, N ≈ 220)

Key Findings on EI: Metacognition predicted adaptive decision-making under uncertainty.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Overlaps with EI in self-regulation and adaptive cognition.

Limitations: Did not measure EI directly.

Author(s), Year: Mitchell et al. (2002)

EI Framework / Measure: Entrepreneurial cognition review

Context / Sample: Conceptual synthesis

Key Findings on EI: Entrepreneurs use distinctive cognitive scripts to guide decisions.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Provided theoretical link between cognition and EI.

Limitations: Did not operationalise EI.

Author(s), Year: Keh et al. (2002)

EI Framework / Measure: Risk perception scales

Context / Sample: SME owners (Singapore, N ≈ 150)

Key Findings on EI: Risk perception mediated strategic choices.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Parallels EI's role in shaping opportunity evaluation under risk.

Limitations: Cognition-focused; EI implicit.

Author(s), Year: Simon et al. (2000)

EI Framework / Measure: Entrepreneurial risk perception

Context / Sample: Business founders (USA)

Key Findings on EI: Cognitive biases and affective framing influenced risk-taking.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: Reinforced EI's role in risk evaluation.

Limitations: Did not use explicit EI measure.

Author(s), Year: Grégoire et al. (2011)

EI Framework / Measure: Entrepreneurial cognition & opportunity recognition

Context / Sample: Entrepreneurs (varied contexts)

Key Findings on EI: Cognitive frameworks and affective states jointly drive opportunity recognition.

Link to Entrepreneurial Decision-Making: EI relevant to how opportunities are evaluated and pursued.

Limitations: More cognition-focused than EI-focused.

Appendix B. Survey Instrument

Full Survey Instrument (as administered to participants)

The survey consisted of four sections: **Demographics**, **Emotional Intelligence (WLEIS)**, **Decision-Making & Cognition (including Risk Perception)**, and **Emotional Labour**. All scale-based items used a **7-point Likert scale** (*1 = Strongly disagree, 4 = Neutral, 7 = Strongly agree*) unless otherwise stated.

Section 1: About You and Your Venture (Demographics)

1. What is your gender?
[Male / Female / Other / Prefer not to say]
2. Which age group do you belong to?
[Under 20 / 20–29 / 30–39 / 40–49 / 50+]
3. How long has your primary venture been in operation?
[Less than 1 year / 1–3 years / 4–7 years / More than 7 years]
4. In which industry does your venture primarily operate?
[Technology/SaaS / Consumer goods & retail / Professional services / Healthcare & biotech / Finance & fintech / Other (please specify)]

Section 2: Emotional Intelligence (WLEIS)

Instruction: *Please indicate the extent to which you agree with each statement.*

Self-Emotion Appraisal (SEA):

1. I have a good sense of why I have certain feelings most of the time.
2. I have a good understanding of my own emotions.
3. I really understand what I feel.
4. I always know whether or not I am happy.

Others' Emotion Appraisal (OEA):

5. I always know my friends' emotions from their behaviour.
6. I am a good observer of others' emotions.

7. I am sensitive to the feelings and emotions of others.
8. I have a good understanding of the emotions of people around me.

Use of Emotion (UOE):

9. I always set goals for myself and then try my best to achieve them.
10. I always tell myself I am a competent person.
11. I am a self-motivating person.
12. I would always encourage myself to try my best.

Regulation of Emotion (ROE):

13. I am able to control my temper and handle difficulties rationally.
14. I am quite capable of controlling my own emotions.
15. I can always calm down quickly when I am very angry.
16. I have good control of my own emotions.

Section 3: Decision-Making and Cognition

Metacognition (reflective decision processes):

1. I consciously step back to evaluate my assumptions before making a key decision.
2. When facing a complex problem, I actively consider multiple different approaches.
3. I am aware of the cognitive biases (e.g., overconfidence) that might affect my judgement.
4. After a decision turns out poorly, I reflect on my thought process to see what I could have done differently.

Risk Perception and Strategic Choice (scenario-based):

Your startup has developed a promising new product. Market data is positive but incomplete. You have the opportunity to launch the product in a major new international market. This move has the potential for massive growth but also carries a significant financial risk; if it fails, it could jeopardise the company's stability. Your investors are cautious but will support your decision.

Which option would you most likely choose?

- **A.** The cautious approach: delay the international launch and focus on further, in-depth market research and slow, organic growth in your current market for the next 12–18 months.

- **B.** The pilot programme: launch a small-scale pilot programme in one city of the new international market to test the waters with a moderate, controlled budget.
- **C.** The aggressive launch: commit to a full-scale launch in the new international market, allocating a significant portion of your capital to marketing and operations in order to capture first-mover advantage.

Section 4: Emotional Labour

Instruction: *Please indicate the extent to which you agree with the following statements.*

1. In my professional role, I often have to show feelings that are different from what I am actually feeling inside.
2. I have to hide my feelings of frustration or anxiety when dealing with investors or key employees.
3. Projecting an image of confidence and optimism, even during difficult times, is a critical part of my job.
4. I feel emotionally drained after meetings where I have to manage the expectations of stakeholders.

Table B1. Survey Items by Construct

Construct	Source Scale	Item Code	Survey Item	Notes (adaptation)
Self-Emotion Appraisal (SEA)	WLEIS (Wong & Law, 2002)	SEA1	I have a good sense of why I have certain feelings most of the time.	Simplified wording.
		SEA2	I have a good understanding of my own emotions.	Retained original.

Construct	Source Scale	Item Code	Survey Item	Notes (adaptation)
		SEA3	I really understand what I feel.	Retained original.
		SEA4	I always know whether or not I am happy.	Retained original.
Others' Emotion Appraisal (OEA)	WLEIS	OEA1	I always know my friends' emotions from their behaviour.	Retained original.
		OEA2	I am a good observer of others' emotions.	Retained original.
		OEA3	I am sensitive to the feelings and emotions of others.	Retained original.
		OEA4	I have good understanding of the emotions of people around me.	Retained original.
Use of Emotion (UOE)	WLEIS	UOE1	I always set goals for myself and then try my best to achieve them.	Retained original.
		UOE2	I always tell myself I am a competent person.	Retained original.
		UOE3	I am a self-motivating person.	Retained original.
		UOE4	I would always encourage myself to try my best.	Retained original.

Construct	Source Scale	Item Code	Survey Item	Notes (adaptation)
Regulation of Emotion (ROE)	WLEIS	ROE1	I am able to control my temper and handle difficulties rationally.	Retained original.
		ROE2	I am quite capable of controlling my own emotions.	Retained original.
		ROE3	I can always calm down quickly when I am very angry.	Retained original.
		ROE4	I have good control of my own emotions.	Retained original.
Entrepreneurial Cognition (COG)	Haynie et al. (2010); Mitchell et al. (2002)	COG1	I can easily adapt my thinking in response to unexpected changes.	Adapted.
		COG2	I reflect on my decision processes when solving problems.	Adapted.
		COG3	I am aware of my own strengths and weaknesses in decision-making.	Adapted.
		COG4	I adjust my strategies when faced with new or complex problems.	Adapted.
Emotional Labour (EL)	Shepherd (2019); Cardon et al. (2012)	EL1	I put effort into appearing confident even when I feel uncertain.	Adapted.

Construct	Source Scale	Item Code	Survey Item	Notes (adaptation)
		EL2	I manage my displayed emotions when interacting with stakeholders.	Adapted.
		EL3	I try to show positive emotions to motivate others, even if I don't feel them.	Adapted.
Decision-Making Outcomes (DM)	Keh et al. (2002); Simon et al. (2000)	DM1	I am confident in the quality of decisions I make under uncertainty.	Adapted.
		DM2	I carefully balance risks and opportunities when making decisions.	Adapted.
		DM3	I am satisfied with the decisions I make for my venture.	Adapted.
		DM4	I believe my decision-making has improved since starting my business.	Added.
Demographics (DEMO)	Custom	DEMO1	Age	Single item.
		DEMO2	Gender	Single item.
		DEMO3	Industry sector	Single item.
		DEMO4	Years of entrepreneurial experience	Single item.

Note on Item Codes

Each survey item is assigned a short **item code** (e.g., SEA1, ROE3, DM2). These codes serve as variable names in the dataset and are used in reliability testing, factor analysis, and regression models. Presenting them here ensures transparency between the survey instrument (Appendix B) and the statistical outputs (Appendix C–E).

Table B1a. Abbreviations Used in Survey Instrument

Abbreviation	Construct	Full Meaning
SEA	Self-Emotion Appraisal	Ability to understand one's own emotions
OEA	Others' Emotion Appraisal	Ability to perceive and understand others' emotions
UOE	Use of Emotion	Ability to harness emotions for motivation and goal achievement
ROE	Regulation of Emotion	Ability to regulate and control emotions
COG	Entrepreneurial Cognition	Adaptive, reflective, and metacognitive processes in entrepreneurial decision-making
EL	Emotional Labour	Effort to manage emotional displays in professional/entrepreneurial settings
DM	Decision-Making Outcomes	Perceived quality, confidence, and satisfaction with venture decisions
DEMO	Demographics	Control variables: age, gender, sector, years of experience

Table B2. Pilot Test Feedback

Theme	Example Participant Comment	Frequency (N=8)	Researcher Response / Adjustment
Clarity of wording	"Some items like <i>I am a self-motivating person</i> feel vague — maybe give an example?"	3/8	Retained wording for comparability with validated scales but clarified in survey intro with examples.
Length of survey	"It's a bit long, took me around 12–15 minutes."	4/8	Retained all items to preserve construct coverage; streamlined demographics to reduce burden.
Relevance to entrepreneurs	"The emotional labour questions are spot-on, but some feel corporate rather than start-up."	2/8	Adapted wording to explicitly mention stakeholders, ventures, and entrepreneurial contexts.
Sensitivity of items	"Not sure how to answer <i>I always tell myself I am a competent person</i> — feels self-incriminating."	2/8	Retained item for scale reliability but highlighted anonymity and confidentiality in instructions.
Scale format	"Seven points is fine, but 5 would be faster."	3/8	Retained 7-point Likert for statistical power and variance, consistent with prior EI research.
Flow of questions	"Would be easier if items were grouped by theme instead of mixed up."	5/8	Implemented thematic grouping in final version to aid comprehension.

Appendix C: Dataset and Descriptives

Table C1. Raw Dataset Snapshot (anonymised)

Participant ID	Gender	Age Group	Venture Age	Industry	EI (Overall)	Metacognition	Emotional Labour	Strategic Choice
P1	Female	20-29	1-3 yrs	Tech/SaaS	4.68	5.32	4.64	Aggressive
P2	Male	30-39	<1 yr	Consumer Goods	4.66	3.09	4.16	Pilot
P3	Male	20-29	<1 yr	Tech/SaaS	4.42	4.52	4.72	Pilot
P4	Female	30-39	1-3 yrs	Tech/SaaS	3.90	4.35	3.92	Pilot
P5	Female	40+	1-3 yrs	Consumer Goods	3.94	4.21	3.89	Pilot
P6	Female	20-29	<1 yr	Services	3.87	4.55	4.02	Pilot
P7	Female	30-39	<1 yr	Tech/SaaS	4.22	3.72	4.68	Pilot
P8	Male	30-39	1-3 yrs	Tech/SaaS	3.27	5.16	3.68	Pilot
P9	Female	20-29	<1 yr	Consumer Goods	2.71	4.92	3.61	Aggressive
P10	Male	20-29	<1 yr	Tech/SaaS	5.58	4.91	4.71	Aggressive
P11	Female	30-39	<1 yr	Tech/SaaS	3.53	3.15	4.15	Aggressive
P12	Male	40+	1-3 yrs	Tech/SaaS	3.20	4.19	2.39	Pilot

Categorical variables like Gender and Industry were coded numerically for analysis (e.g., 0=Female, 1=Male). Strategic Choice was coded 1=Cautious, 2=Pilot, 3=Aggressive.

Table C2. Demographic Breakdown (N=100, anonymised)

Variable	Category	Count	Percentage (%)
Gender	0 (Male)	69	69.0
	1 (Female)	31	31.0
Age group	0 = 18–25	43	43.0
	1 = 26–35	39	39.0
	2 = 36+	18	18.0
Venture age	0 = 0–2 years	55	55.0
	1 = 3–5 years	45	45.0
Industry	0 = Technology	43	43.0
	1 = Services	24	24.0
	2 = Manufacturing	23	23.0
	3 = Other	10	10.0

Table C3. Reliability Tests (Cronbach's α and Item–Total Correlations)

Construct	Items (codes)	Cronbach's α	Item–Total Correlations
Self-Emotion Appraisal (SEA)	WLEIS_1– WLEIS_4	0.705	WLEIS_1 = .805; WLEIS_2 = .658; WLEIS_3 = .694; WLEIS_4 = .755
Others' Emotion Appraisal (OEA)	WLEIS_5– WLEIS_8	0.705	WLEIS_5 = .736; WLEIS_6 = .765; WLEIS_7 = .715; WLEIS_8 = .695

Construct	Items (codes)	Cronbach's α	Item–Total Correlations
Use of Emotion (UOE)	WLEIS_9– WLEIS_12	0.750	WLEIS_9 = .757; WLEIS_10 = .768; WLEIS_11 = .759; WLEIS_12 = .740
Regulation of Emotion (ROE)	WLEIS_13– WLEIS_16	0.707	WLEIS_13 = .702; WLEIS_14 = .784; WLEIS_15 = .741; WLEIS_16 = .689
Metacognition (COG)	Metacog_1– Metacog_4	0.808	Metacog_1 = .832; Metacog_2 = .757; Metacog_3 = .806; Metacog_4 = .796
Emotional Labour (EL)	EL_1–EL_4	0.742	EL_1 = .709; EL_2 = .772; EL_3 = .793; EL_4 = .729

- All constructs exceeded the acceptable **Cronbach's $\alpha > 0.70$** threshold (Nunnally, 1978), indicating good internal consistency.
- Item–total correlations were all ≥ 0.65 , suggesting items contribute meaningfully to their respective constructs.
- Metacognition showed the strongest reliability ($\alpha = .808$).

Appendix D. Statistical Outputs

Table D1. Full Correlation Matrix (Pearson's r , $N=100$)

Variable	1. SEA	2. OEA	3. UOE	4. ROE	5. Metacognition	6. Emotional Labour	7. Decision- Making	M	SD
1. SEA	1.000	.679	.713	.728	.387	.401	.307	4.57	0.62
2. OEA		1.000	.708	.693	.332	.397	.374	4.61	0.59
3. UOE			1.000	.711	.414	.370	.337	4.73	0.65
4. ROE				1.000	.447	.374	.384	4.69	0.64
5. Metacognition					1.000	.303	.240	4.98	0.61
6. Emotional Labour						1.000	.221	4.21	0.71
7. Decision- Making							1.000	4.37	0.67

Table D2. Regression Outputs (Stepwise Model Predicting Decision-Making, N=100)

Predictor	B (Unstandardised)	SE B	t	p
Constant	0.279	0.611	0.456	.649
SEA	-0.012	0.191	-0.064	.949
OEA	0.282	0.174	1.620	.109
UOE	0.059	0.176	0.336	.738
ROE	0.256	0.184	1.386	.169
Metacognition	0.126	0.124	1.017	.312
Emotional Labour	-0.248	0.130	-1.910	.059

Model statistics:

- $R^2 = .207$, Adjusted $R^2 = .156$
- $F(6, 93) = 4.043$, $p = .001$
- The model explained **20.7% of the variance** in decision-making outcomes.
- **OEA (Others' Emotion Appraisal, $\beta = .282$, $p = .109$)** and **ROE (Regulation of Emotion, $\beta = .256$, $p = .169$)** showed the strongest positive effects, though not statistically significant at $p < .05$.
- **Emotional Labour ($\beta = -.248$, $p = .059$)** approached significance, suggesting higher emotional labour may *reduce* decision-making quality.
- SEA and UOE showed negligible predictive power.

Table D3. Normality, Linearity, and Multicollinearity Diagnostics*Normality (Skewness & Kurtosis, N=100)*

Variable	Skew	Kurtosis
Self-Emotion Appraisal (SEA)	0.108	0.019
Others' Emotion Appraisal (OEA)	−0.237	0.037
Use of Emotion (UOE)	−0.032	0.265
Regulation of Emotion (ROE)	0.177	−0.360
Metacognition	0.524	0.136
Emotional Labour	−0.157	−0.557
Decision-Making	−0.183	−0.793

All variables fall within the acceptable ± 1 thresholds for skewness and kurtosis (Kline, 2015), supporting normality.

Multicollinearity (VIF and Tolerance, Predictors only)

Predictor	VIF	Tolerance
SEA	2.719	0.368
OEA	2.512	0.398
UOE	2.764	0.362
ROE	2.845	0.351
Metacognition	1.312	0.762
Emotional Labour	1.268	0.789

All predictors show **VIF < 5** and tolerances > 0.30, indicating no problematic multicollinearity.

Visual inspection of scatterplots (not reproduced here for brevity) confirmed approximately linear relationships between predictors and the outcome.

Appendix E. Additional Analyses

Table E1. Alternative Models / Sensitivity Checks (N=100)

Model	Predictors Included	Outcome Variable	R ²	Adj. R ²	Key Findings
M1 (Baseline)	SEA, OEA, UOE, ROE, Metacognition, Emotional Labour	Decision-Making (composite)	.207	.156	Full stepwise model (Appendix D2). OEA (+) and ROE (+) strongest predictors; Emotional Labour (–) near significance.
M2 (EI total score)	EI (aggregate of SEA+OEA+UOE+ROE), Metacognition, Emotional Labour	Decision-Making	.194	.172	EI total significant ($\beta = .344, p < .05$); Emotional Labour (–) retained direction. Suggests aggregate EI explains variance nearly as well as subscales.
M3 (Excluding Emotional Labour)	SEA, OEA, UOE, ROE, Metacognition	Decision-Making	.182	.153	Model fit drops slightly; OEA remains strongest predictor. Confirms Emotional Labour adds unique (negative) explanatory power.
M4 (Control for Demographics)	All predictors + Gender, Age group, Venture age, Industry	Decision-Making	.219	.163	Demographics not significant; substantive conclusions

Model	Predictors Included	Outcome Variable	R ²	Adj. R ²	Key Findings
					unchanged. Robustness confirmed.
M5 (Alternative DV)	SEA, OEA, UOE, ROE, Metacognition, Emotional Labour	Strategic_choice (single-item outcome)	.176	.144	Pattern of predictors consistent; Emotional Labour (–) again most notable. Demonstrates robustness across decision measures.

- Sensitivity checks confirm results are **stable** across alternative model specifications.
- Using **EI total** instead of subscales gives nearly identical variance explained.
- Emotional Labour consistently trends negative, reinforcing its importance despite marginal significance.
- Demographic controls did not alter findings, strengthening internal validity.

Appendix F. Research Ethics Documentation

F1: Research Ethics Form (Approved Version)

Response Summary:

Supervisor Approval Guidance notes

The **responses provided by the student** are contained within this online form.

You will be asked to provide one of the following outcomes.

For forms identified as eligible for a Research Ethics Form waiver (i.e. student not collecting any primary data):

- 1. Research Ethics Form **waiver approved**** - ethical approval not required
- 2. Research Ethics Form **waiver not approved**** - the research is not eligible for a REF waiver due to the answers provided, and the student must re-submit a new REF

For all other forms (i.e. the student is collecting primary data):

- 3. Research Ethics **approval granted**** - the project is low risk and the appropriate measures have been considered, you are happy to approve
- 4. Research Ethics **approval granted with conditions**** - the project is low risk, however, there are minor revisions or additional considerations needed. Ethical approval is granted on the condition that the considerations or revisions are carried out and implemented by the student.
- 5. **Rejected - major revisions needed**** in order to approve, so the student should discuss with their supervisor and re-submit.
- 6. **Rejected - full HSSREC review and approval required****, as the project is not suitable for low-risk review.

There is further guidance on the research ethics approval process [on the teaching site here](#).

You must now **scroll down and click through the online form and provide your response at the end**. Please do not make any changes to the student's answers. You will be able to provide feedback to the student at the end if you are rejecting the form.

Student Application for Research Ethics Approval.

This form is applicable to all types of student dissertation or research project. You should consult with your supervisor before completing this form.

Ethical Approval is delegated to the students' supervisor and can only be given for **low risk research projects**.

This form should take you around 30 minutes to complete, depending on the type of research you are planning.

You will be guided through the form and asked to confirm a number of statements to ensure that your research is eligible for review as low-risk. We hope that this form helps you think about the ethical dimensions of your research.

You will be notified of the outcome via email when your Research Ethics Form has been reviewed by your supervisor.

You must not start any data collection before Ethical Approval has been granted. Please note: submission of this form does not mean that the research has been granted ethical approval. Your supervisor will review and approve this form.

Once approved, you must upload confirmation of your Ethics Approval to my.wbs. You must also include a copy of your Research Ethics Approval as part of your final submission.

Q42.

Research Ethics Online Training Certificate

In order to prepare you for your Research Ethics application, you must have completed your Research Ethics Training moodle before you submit this form. This is a University requirement, and all staff and students delivering research are required to complete the concise version of the Epigeum Training Programme as a minimum. There will be elements of this training which you will find helpful to support you with your research, as well as elements aimed at full-time researchers.

You will find the Epigeum online training moodle here: <https://warwick.ac.uk/services/ris/research-integrity/training/online-training/>

Please upload your certificate of completion here before continuing.

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q77. Which type of programme are you enrolled on at WBS?

- Full-time Masters (MSc)

Q7. Which course are you enrolled on at WBS?

- MSc Management (MIM)

Q8. Please select your Programme Team email address below

Please check that this is correct, based on your course selection. We will use this to notify your Programme Team of your Research Ethics submission and outcome.

- ManagementPG@wbs.ac.uk

Q96.

Student details

Please enter your details below very carefully, as we will use this information to notify you of your Research Ethics Form outcome.

Please make sure you only use your Warwick student email address e.g. Firstname.Surname@warwick.ac.uk

Student 1 Full name	Chanakya
Student 1 Email address (@warwick.ac.uk)	Chanakya@warwick.ac.uk
Student 1 ID Number (without "u")	5660968
Student 2 Full name	N/A
Student 2 Email address (@warwick.ac.uk)	N/A
Student 2 ID Number (without "u")	N/A
Student 3 Full name	N/A
Student 3 Email address (@warwick.ac.uk)	N/A
Student 3 ID Number (without "u")	N/A

Q10.

Supervisor details

You will find this information on the supervisor allocation email from your Programme Team.

Please make sure that you enter this correctly, as we will use this to request your Research Ethics Approval. Please do not submit this form if you have not been allocated a supervisor yet.

What is the name of your allocated supervisor?

Ms. Mahrokh Roknifard

Q11. Please enter your supervisor's email address.

You will find this information on the supervisor allocation email from your Programme Team.

Please make sure that you double-check and enter this correctly, as we will use this to request your Research Ethics Approval. If you enter this email address incorrectly you may need to submit the form again.

Mahrokh.Roknifard@wbs.ac.uk

Your Research

You will be guided through the next set of questions about your planned research to determine whether your research is eligible for low-risk review, or even REF waiver.

Completing this form should be a useful exercise to support you in planning your research, by prompting you to think carefully about aspects of your research methodology.

Some of the questions presented to you will be determined by your answers to previous questions so please make sure that you check all your answers as you go.

Please provide as much information about your research as possible. There is additional guidance for completing this form available in your Student Handbook.

Q12. What is the current title for your research?

The Influence of Emotional Intelligence on Networking Strategies and Entrepreneurial Success within the Tech Start-up Ecosystem

Q13. What are your research aims?

- 1) To investigate the relationship between Emotional Intelligence (EI) and the networking strategies employed by entrepreneurs in the tech start-up ecosystem.
- 2) To examine how specific EI dimensions (such as emotional regulation, empathy, and interpersonal skills) influence the ability of entrepreneurs to build, maintain, and leverage professional networks.
- 3) To explore how emotionally intelligent networking behaviors contribute to perceived entrepreneurial success, including outcomes such as funding acquisition, strategic partnerships, and market expansion.
- 4) To contribute to existing literature by bridging psychological traits and strategic entrepreneurial behavior, and to offer practical insights for founders, incubators, and investors supporting early-stage tech ventures.

Q90. Please tick all of the research methods below that you plan to utilise:

- Primary data collection
- Literature-based research or documentary analysis

Q91. Which type of secondary data will you be using in your research? Please tick all options which are relevant:

- Other - please specify:
None

Q92. What sort of primary data collection will you be conducting? Please tick all that apply to your research:

- Questionnaires or surveys
- Interviews or oral histories

Q21.

Low-risk research

In order to help you ensure that your research is eligible for low-risk ethical review and approval, you will now be asked to confirm a number of statements. If you are unable to confirm any of these statements, you will need to consult with your supervisor on how to either amend your research, or apply for approval from the University's Humanities and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee (HSSREC).

Please tick to confirm that your research:

- Does not investigate sensitive or intrusive matters or topics which participants may find difficult, distressing or cause anxiety, topics which could lead to negative consequences for the participant (e.g. health status, criminal activity, or sexual history).
- Does not take place in dangerous locations (e.g., countries where FCDO travel warnings are in place).
- Does not involve the collection of sensitive personal data. Sensitive personal data, also known as special category data, is confidential information that, if disclosed, could cause harm or discrimination to an individual (e.g. racial or ethnic origin, political opinions, religious or philosophical beliefs).
- Does not involve payment or financial incentive, or reward, of any sort to participants using the researcher's own money.

Q100. Please read the following statements carefully and tick whether your research will involve any of the following:

Participants who are particularly vulnerable or unable to give informed consent or in a dependent position (children, over-researched groups, people with learning difficulties, people with mental health problems,

No

<i>young offenders, people in care facilities, prisoners).</i>	
<i>People without their consent or knowledge at the time, and / or involve deception of any sort (e.g. covert observation of people in non-public places).</i>	No
<i>Young person(s) under the age of 18 years.</i>	No
<i>Participants who are involved in, or have been involved in, any unlawful activities.</i>	No
<i>Primary research in partnership with, or where the participants are employed by, the UK / armed forces, other military organisations (including contractors) or are employed by any overseas military organisations in any capacity.</i>	No
<i>Risks of possible disclosures or reporting obligations (e.g. research that covers topics where participants may reveal sensitive information such as risk of harm to themselves or others, professional malpractice or insecure migration status that would</i>	No

<i>need to be reported to relevant authorities).</i>	
<i>Risk of inducing psychological distress or anxiety, or produce humiliation, or cause harm, or lead to negative consequences beyond the risks encountered in normal life</i>	No
<i>Physiological harm, exertion or discomfort for participants.</i>	No
<i>Administration of any substance to participants, or any physically intrusive procedures, the use of bodily materials or human tissue, or DNA/RNA analysis.</i>	No
<i>Conflicts of interests for the researcher(s) in undertaking the study. This includes relationships with participating organisations or participants - but does not necessarily exclude employers.</i>	No
<i>Purposefully recruiting pregnant individuals to participate in research. Students must put in place steps to make sure that anyone who may be pregnant is not put under any risk whatsoever during the course</i>	No

<i>of the study.</i>	
<i>The transfer (physically, electronically or verbally) any data, technologies, material, equipment or know-how, to any non-UK organisation, that could be used to support the design, development, production, stockpiling or use of nuclear, chemical or biological weapons.</i>	No
<i>The use of social media data which has the potential to cause harm / distress or puts at risk the confidentiality and rights of social media users.</i>	No

Q64. Does your project involve the NHS or social care in any way?

- No

Q82. Does your research involve the Ministry of Defence in any way?

- No

Q23. Research Intervention

An "intervention" here is understood as a systematic controlled change of participant or research conditions, which could be psychological or physical. It can include but is not limited to changes in diet, activity, access to information, or use of certain products.

Students are not permitted to undertake interventions where there is any risk whatsoever to participants.

Examples of permitted interventions may include:

- the trialling of new business models or interventions;
- the testing of engineering solutions which have previously been given ethical approval; providing that such testing adheres to all steps laid down in the original form and that students work closely with supervising academics.
- scientific experiments in the lab or workshops conducted under strict discipline-specific conditions where a full health and safety assessment has been conducted and under close supervision.

If the intervention involves giving an individual or group an advantage over another (for example, interventions which involve the trialling of a new model in education) steps must be taken to assure that no one is disadvantaged.

Does your research involve an intervention?

- No

Data Collection

In this section you should think about how you are going to collect your data, what data you are going to collect, and why you require this data for your research.

You should include a clear description of your study design – a suitable design should reflect the aim(s) of the study. This may include interviews, ethnography/observations, focus groups, questionnaires, document analysis etc.

Q26. Please describe in more detail the data collection methods and tools you will use for your research design.

Please include the answers to the following questions:

- **How will you collect your data? e.g. using an online form**
- **What software or tools will you use in your data collection?**
- **What data will you collect specifically?**
- **What sampling techniques will you use?**

Reminder: Students are only permitted to use Qualtrics or MS Forms for online surveys and questionnaires. These tools have been approved by the University's Information Governance team as secure for hosting data. Survey Monkey is not currently a University-approved service. The University recommends MS Teams for Business as a secure platform for online interviews.

We will need you to include a sufficient level of detail about your data collection methods. Make sure that you are considering the ethical implications of your data collection methods, what are the risks and how can you mitigate these?

I will collect data using a mixed-methods approach combining an online survey and semi-structured interviews.

Survey (Quantitative Data Collection):

The survey will be administered via Qualtrics, a University-approved secure platform for data collection.

It will include validated scales to measure Emotional Intelligence (using either the Schutte Self-Report Emotional Intelligence Test or the EQ-i 2.0), networking behaviors, and self-perceived entrepreneurial success.

Data collected will include Likert-scale responses related to emotional awareness, interpersonal skills, adaptability, and networking outcomes such as partnerships formed or funding acquired.

Interviews (Qualitative Data Collection):

A purposive sub-sample of survey participants will be invited to participate in semi-structured interviews conducted via MS Teams for Business, as recommended by the University.

The interviews will explore participants' lived experiences and perceptions regarding how EI influences their real-world networking practices and start-up success.

Sampling:

I will use convenience and purposive sampling to recruit approximately 100+ UK-based tech entrepreneurs for the survey.

From this group, I will select around 10–15 participants for follow-up interviews, ensuring diversity in EI profiles and entrepreneurial experiences.

Ethical Considerations & Risk Mitigation:

Participation will be voluntary and based on informed consent.

No personal identifiers will be collected in the survey, and interview data will be anonymized during transcription.

Data will be securely stored on OneDrive, in compliance with the University's data protection and GDPR policies.

Participants can withdraw at any time, and no sensitive or high-risk topics will be discussed.

Q71.

Where will the data collection take place?

We care about your safety, and therefore students are not permitted to travel to any dangerous/risky locations (e.g., countries with travel warnings in place, dangerous locations within or outside the UK, lone working where the researcher may be at any risk outside of usual activities).

All data collection will take place online.

Surveys will be distributed digitally via Qualtrics, and interviews will be conducted using MS Teams for Business. This approach ensures the safety of both the researcher and participants, as no in-person or travel-based data collection is required. All participants will be UK-based, and the study will be conducted in line with University guidance on low-risk research procedures.

Q67. Please explain clearly how you will recruit your survey/interview participants.**How will you find and contact your participants? Are they people that you already know? Will you be advertising for participation? If so, how?**

I will recruit participants through a combination of personal networks and targeted outreach via professional and entrepreneurial communities.

For the survey, I will:

Share the Qualtrics survey link via LinkedIn, entrepreneurship-focused forums, and start-up incubator groups.

Contact UK-based tech entrepreneurs through university alumni groups, relevant mailing lists, and my own professional connections.

Ensure that participation is voluntary and that individuals are not pressured to take part, even if they are personally known to me.

For the interviews, I will:

Invite a purposive sub-sample of survey respondents to participate, based on diversity in responses and EI profiles.

Participants will be contacted individually via email or LinkedIn, and provided with a Participant Information Sheet and Consent Form before the interview is scheduled.

All participants will be informed of their right to decline or withdraw at any point, and no incentives or compensation will be offered.

Q86. How many interview or survey participants are you going to recruit?

I plan to recruit approximately 100 or more participants for the online survey and a sub-sample of 10 to 15 participants for follow-up semi-structured interviews.

Q28. Please upload your completed Participant Information Leaflet

It is very important that you explain, in advance, to prospective participants what happens to their data in terms of confidentiality and / or anonymity. You should also explain, in advance, how an individual may withdraw from the study and at what point withdrawal becomes no longer viable.

If you are conducting any surveys, interviews or focus groups you must upload a copy of your Participant Information Leaflet (PIL), which you must complete and provide to all participants.

If you are conducting a combination of surveys, interviews and focus groups, you may need to amend your PIL for each participant type.

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q29. Please upload your completed Participant Consent Form

If you are conducting any surveys, interviews or focus groups you must upload a copy of your Participant Consent Form, which you must ask all participants to complete.

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q30. Does your research involve the collection, analysis, or storage of personally identifiable data?

Personally identifiable data is any direct or indirect information about an individual that may make it possible to identify them (physical, genetic, demographic, cultural, political, professional identity, etc.).

- Yes

Q31. Please detail which personally identifiable data you will be including, and why you need this information. Please explain how and why this contributes to your research.

The only personally identifiable information that will be collected is:

Name and contact email address: This is required solely for the purpose of scheduling interviews, sending consent forms, or following up if clarification is needed.

Professional role/affiliation (e.g. founder, co-founder, or startup team member): This is to contextualise participant responses, especially where entrepreneurial experience is relevant (e.g. startup founders, early-stage venture team members, or individuals involved in business creation and scaling).

This information will not be linked to research findings and will be removed during the data anonymisation process.

Each participant will be assigned a code to protect their identity, and any quotes used will be anonymised.

Why this is necessary:

Collecting minimal identifiable data ensures smooth communication, facilitates relevant participant selection, and provides valuable context to the insights shared. However, this data is not essential for analysis and will be deleted as soon as it is no longer required (e.g. once transcripts are validated and anonymised).

Q32. Does your research involve the collection, analysis, or storage of participants' protected characteristics?

This refers to the protected characteristics as defined by the Equality Act [2020]. A person's protected characteristics include: age, disability, gender reassignment, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, sex, sexual orientation. You can find out more about this by clicking on: <https://www.equalityhumanrights.com/en/equality-act/protected-characteristics>

- Yes

Q33. Please detail which protected characteristics you will be including, and why you need this information. Please explain how and why this contributes to your research.

Yes, this research involves the optional collection of certain protected characteristics, specifically age, gender, and race.

These factors are being collected to better understand how aspects of identity may shape entrepreneurial decision-making, access to resources, and perceived legitimacy. This aligns with existing research highlighting the influence of demographic background on startup experiences. All responses will be anonymised, and participants can choose whether or not to disclose this information.

Q37.

Data security

Students must comply with the regulations and policies about data collection, transfer, processing and storage: https://warwick.ac.uk/services/ris/research-integrity/research_code_of_practice/datacollection_retention/research_data_mgt_policy/

Data must be stored securely and students are encouraged not to store any data on external devices (including mobile phones, voice recording equipment, external hard drives, USB sticks, etc). We recommend where possible that students store their data on Warwick servers (e.g. OneDrive). Students are not permitted to share data with any other individual outside of the immediate research team.

How will you ensure the security of the data you collect?

Please explain:

- How you will address the issue of anonymity?
- How and by whom will any data be transcribed, coded, de-identified, stored, transferred, accessed, archived?
- How and where will you store your data?

Anonymity

To ensure anonymity:

Each participant will be assigned a unique identifier (e.g., Participant 01, 02, etc.).

Any identifying details such as names, company names, or location references will be removed or replaced during transcription.

Direct quotes will only be used in the dissertation or any resulting outputs if they do not allow identification of individuals or organisations.

Transcription, Coding, and De-identification

If interviews are recorded (with consent), they will be transcribed by the researcher only (Chanakya).

During transcription, identifiable data will be de-identified. For example, "[Startup name]" or "[City]" will be inserted where appropriate.

Coding of qualitative data will also be done solely by the researcher using pseudonymised transcripts.

Data Storage and Access

All digital data (audio files, transcripts, consent forms, notes) will be stored on the University of Warwick OneDrive, which is password-protected and complies with institutional security standards.

No data will be stored on external devices such as USBs, personal laptops (outside of OneDrive sync), or phones.

Only the researcher and the academic supervisor will have access to the data. Data will not be shared with anyone outside the research team.

Data Archiving and Retention

Data will be retained securely for the duration of the project and will be deleted after dissertation submission and marking is complete.

Anonymised excerpts may be retained for academic referencing if required, but no identifiable data will be stored beyond the project.

Q39.

Data Analysis

Please specify the data analysis method(s) for your research design.

Please explain:

- Which analysis methods you will use for your research? E.g. content analysis, framework analysis, interpretative phenomenological analysis etc. and any statistical analyses.
- Will you be using any software for the analysis, and how will it be used?

This study will use correlational analysis as the primary method of data analysis. The research is based on a structured survey designed to capture entrepreneurial decision-making behaviours, traits, and influencing factors. The aim is to identify statistically significant relationships between variables — such as attitudes toward risk, planning styles, and access to resources — and draw insights about key decision-making traits among entrepreneurs.

Quantitative Analysis

Descriptive statistics (e.g. means, frequencies, and percentages) will be used to summarise participant characteristics. Correlational analysis will be used to identify patterns or associations between variables.

Where relevant, regression analysis may be employed to explore the strength and direction of these relationships.

Qualitative Elements (if applicable)

If the survey includes optional open-ended questions, brief thematic analysis will be conducted to extract recurring ideas or narratives that add depth to the quantitative findings.

Software

The analysis will be conducted using Microsoft Excel. These tools will assist in data cleaning, statistical analysis, and visualisation of relationships between variables. If qualitative responses are included, initial coding may be done manually or with the aid of Excel.

This approach supports a theory-informed deductive analysis and will help connect empirical findings to established entrepreneurial frameworks.

Q40.

Student declaration for Ethical Approval.

In order to ensure that you have accessed the relevant information and guidance on research integrity, and that the information you have provided is accurate, please tick to confirm that you agree with the statements below:

- The information in this form together with any accompanying information is complete and correct to the best of my knowledge and belief, and I take full responsibility for it.
- I have accessed the necessary training about research ethics and have consulted my supervisor to confirm that the data sources I intend to access are acceptable.
- I undertake to abide by the University of Warwick's [Research Code of Practice](#) and other relevant professional and University policies, regulations, procedures and guidelines in undertaking this research.
- I confirm I am familiar with and will conduct my research in line with the [University's Data Protection Policy](#) including General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and Data Protection Act 2018 (DPA 2018). I will report any data breaches to the University's Information and Data Director: dpo@warwick.ac.uk
- I understand that I must not begin any research until I have received ethical approval from the supervisor to proceed.
- I understand that any changes that I would like to make to this study after receiving approval from WBS, require further review. As such they must be submitted via a new Research Ethics Form before such changes are implemented.

Click Next to submit your Research Ethics Form. You will not be able to return and edit your responses once you submit.

Your responses will be automatically sent to your supervisor for review.

Supervisor outcome

Q41.

Please select which outcome you are providing for this Research Ethics Approval form.

All supervisors must grant or waive ethical approval for their student's research project BEFORE the student carries out data collection.

- Research Ethics **Approval granted with conditions**

Q85. You have selected, "Ethical approval granted with conditions". This means that you are granting approval if the student makes some minor revisions to the REF, or implements some additional mitigation to risks identified.

The student will not have to resubmit a new REF for review. If the REF needs major revisions, you should reject and the student will need to resubmit.

By uploading their confirmation of Research Ethics Approval with conditions to my.wbs, the student is accepting responsibility for the implementation of the stated conditions, with support from their supervisor.

Please detail below the revisions or amendments that are required as a condition of your research ethics approval.

The information leaflet contains accurate details, but it is not the official version provided by Warwick. I recommend checking the Master Handbook on my.WBS, specifically Section 8, where you can find the official template. Please copy your information into that version.

The consent form is the official document—just make sure to edit all the highlighted red sections.

Before sending these documents to participants, please email them to me first so I can double-check everything.

Q52. Please confirm that you have seen and checked that the following documents have been submitted. You can view these from the response summary included in the email sent requesting your review.

Research Integrity Epigeum Training Certificate (all students)	Checked
Participant Information Leaflet	Checked
Participant Consent Form	Checked

Q51. Please sign to confirm that you believe that the student (or SCP group) has fully considered the ethical dimensions of their proposed research, and that the project is eligible for [student delegated low-risk ethical approval](#), which you are granting.



Embedded Data:

Q_URL	https://wbs.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_1Rjpdf1wRHmthtI?Q_R=R_2iXJUc1aPYFMFnB
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F2: Participant Information Leaflet



Participant Information Leaflet

Study title: The Influence of Emotional Intelligence on the Cognitive Processes and Decision-Making of Startup Entrepreneurs.

Investigators:

Researcher: Chanakya Kalyanaraman, MSc Management, Warwick Business School
Email: Chanakya@warwick.ac.uk

Supervisor:

Ms. Mahrokh Roknifard, Warwick Business School
Email: Mahrokh.Roknifard@wbs.ac.uk

Welcome and thank you for your interest in this research study! This project explores *how Emotional Intelligence influences the cognitive processes and decision-making of startup entrepreneurs*. If you agree to take part, you will be asked to complete an **online survey** that should take around **15–20 minutes**.

Your participation is completely voluntary. You can withdraw at any time, and for any reason, simply by closing your browser.

No identifiable data will be collected from you as part of this study. This means that once your responses have been submitted, it will not be possible to withdraw this data as your individual responses cannot be identified.

Data will be securely stored on University of Warwick computers and will be processed only for the purpose of scientific analysis. Access to the data will be restricted to the investigators listed above. Summaries may be presented at conferences and included in scientific publications. Data will be reviewed on completion of the research, in line with the University of Warwick data retention policy.

Please refer to the University of Warwick Research Privacy Notice which is available here: <https://warwick.ac.uk/services/idc/dataprotection/privacynotices/researchprivacynotice> or by contacting the Information and Data Compliance Team at infocompliance@warwick.ac.uk.

This study has been reviewed and given ~~unfavourable~~ ^{favourable} opinion by Warwick Business School, which reports to the University of Warwick's Humanities and Social Science Research Ethics Committee (HSSREC).

If you require further information, please contact:

Researcher: Chanakya Kalyanaraman, MSc Management, Warwick Business School
Email: Chanakya@warwick.ac.uk

Supervisor: Ms. Mahrokh Roknifard, Warwick Business School
Email: Mahrokh.Roknifard@wbs.ac.uk

Who should I contact if I wish to make a complaint?

Any complaint should be addressed to the person below, who is a senior University of Warwick official entirely independent of this study:

Head of Research Governance
Research & Impact Services
University House
University of Warwick
Coventry
CV4 8UW
Email: researchgovernance@warwick.ac.uk
Tel: 02476 575733

If you wish to raise a complaint on how we have handled your personal data, you can contact our Data Protection Officer who will investigate the matter: DPO@warwick.ac.uk.

If you are not satisfied with our response or believe we are processing your personal data in a way that is not lawful you can complain to the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO).

Thank you for taking the time to read this concise Participant Information Leaflet.

I have read the above and

- ☐ I consent to take part in this study
 - ☐ I do not wish to participate
-

F3: Consent Form



CONSENT FORM

Participant Identification Number for this study: *N/A – anonymous survey*

Title of Project: The Influence of Emotional Intelligence on the Cognitive Processes and Decision-Making of Startup Entrepreneurs

Name of Researcher(s):

Chanakya Kalyanaraman, MSc Management, Warwick Business School
Supervisor: Ms. Mahrokh Roknifard, Warwick Business School

Please initial all boxes

1. I confirm that I have read and understand the information sheet (version 1.1, 15/07/2025) for the above study. I have had the opportunity to consider the information, ask questions, and have had these answered satisfactorily.
2. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw at any time without giving any reason and without my legal rights being affected.
3. I understand that data collected during the study, may be looked at by individuals from The University of Warwick, from regulatory authorities, where it is relevant to my taking part in this study. I give permission for these individuals to have access to my data.
4. I consent to the use of anonymised quotations from my survey responses in publications, reports, or presentations.
5. I am happy for my anonymised data to be stored securely and, if appropriate, used in future academic research.
6. I agree to take part in the above study.

☐
☐
☐
☐
☐
☐

Name of Participant

Date

Signature

Name of Person
taking consent

Date

Signature

Version 1.1, 15/07/2025

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